COMMONWEALTH OF AUSTRALIA

Proof Committee Hansard

JOINT STANDING COMMITTEE ON ELECTORAL MATTERS

Inquiry into the 2025 federal election

(Public)

WEDNESDAY, 10 DECEMBER 2025

SPRING HILL BRISBANE

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JOINT STANDING COMMITTEE ON ELECTORAL MATTERS

Wednesday, 10 December 2025

Members in attendance: Senators Colbeck and Mulholland and Mr Burnell, Mr Caldwell, Ms Campbell, Mr Laxale, Mr Neumann and Dr Ryan

Terms of Reference for the Inquiry:

That the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters inquire into and report on all aspects of the conduct of the 2025 federal election and related matters, including consideration of the following:

- assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials;
- potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour;
- the suitability and potential reform of measures to ensure universal voter access, including polling booth availability and location, early voting, remote polling, and postal voting arrangements; and
- the suitability of the current authorisation framework and requirements, having regard to the evolution of communication methods and technology.

The Special Minister of State has also asked the Committee to consider the interaction with the following:

- the implementation and operation of the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament, particularly regarding the use of money or capital in the most recent election;
- reforms to address the ongoing threats of interference in our electoral system, both foreign and domestic; and
- the composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate.

WITNESSES

BARTLETT, Mr Andrew, Private capacity **20**
BARTLEY, Mrs Merryl, Private capacity **32**
FOREMAN, Mrs Joanne, Private capacity **32**
HALL, Ms Emi, Director, Operations, Foundations for Tomorrow **15**
JORDAN, Mr Travis, Private Capacity **9**
LING, Mr Chek, Private capacity **32**
ORR, Professor Graeme, Private capacity **27**
ROSE, Mrs Pamela, Private capacity **32**
TILEY, Ms Carmel, Private capacity **32**
WILLIAMS, Dr Paul Douglas, Private capacity **1**

WILLIAMS, Dr Paul Douglas, Private capacity

Committee met at 10:01

CHAIR (Mr Laxale): I declare open this public hearing of the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters for its inquiry into the 2025 federal election. I remind members of the media who may be present or listening on the web of the need to fairly and accurately report the proceedings of this committee. I now welcome Associate Professor Paul Williams to give evidence today.

Dr Williams: I am an associate professor at Griffith University. Today I'm speaking on my own behalf and as a political scientist, and my views don't necessarily reflect the university.

CHAIR: Although the committee does not require you to give evidence under oath, I should advise you that this hearing is a legal proceeding of the parliament and therefore has the same standing as proceedings of the respective houses. The giving of false or misleading evidence is a serious matter and may be regarded as contempt of parliament. The evidence given today attracts parliamentary privilege. I now invite you to make a brief opening statement before we proceed to discussion.

Dr Williams: Thanks again to the committee for inviting me. I think it's a real honour to be able to participate in these types of proceedings. I'm a passionate supporter, obviously, of the parliament and the electoral process. I'm not sure if everyone's got access to the document that I only uploaded this morning. I emailed it to the committee chair this morning, so I'm not sure how much of it you've read or if you've got it open in front of you, but I'm not going to bore you by reading it point by point. I will go through a few of the points. An important caveat: what I'm about to say probably isn't news to any of you. You're all experienced politicians. You've all heard these arguments I'm about to make. But because they are repeated arguments doesn't necessarily weaken their importance. The arguments I am about to make are probably well-known to you.

I am a passionate supporter of maintaining the status quo of three-year parliamentary terms to the House of Representatives for a number of reasons, which I'll go into. It does make Australia an outlier, and New Zealand as well. Most countries have five- or four-year terms, and only six countries have three-year terms. Let's go into some of the arguments why four-year terms is advocated. One of them, of course, is that it will bring us into line internationally. You would have heard this to the point it's become folklore—that four-year terms would give governments more time to actually govern. In the three-year cycle, the first year is bedding down a legislative agenda, establishing relations with the fourth estate and so on. The second year is the only year of governance, and the third year is preparation, with electoral matters, campaigning, public relations. I've never bought that argument. We know that the Gillard minority government was a flurry of activity, and we know that last year, in 2024, the Albanese government passed 140 bills, including 30 right at the end. So I think it's a bit of a furphy that the first and third years are not hives of activity. I think that they are, and I don't think that argument stands up to scrutiny—that only the second year of a parliament is worthy of legislative activity.

The second argument is more about why I defend flexible parliamentary terms. I'm not a fan of fixed parliamentary terms. But the big argument for fixed parliamentary terms is obviously to remove the expediency or opportunity of an incumbent prime minister for calling an election at a time when their party or they themselves are riding high in the opinion polls. This was certainly the case in 1955, when Robert Menzies called an early election to capitalise on Labor's anti-communist sentiment or split. Again, Bob Hawke in 1984 called an early election to capitalise on his its own popularity. Yes, I have to concede that expediency does sound unfair. But the point is that both major party blocs, Labor and the coalition, enjoy this advantage at different times, so the advantage, in my view, is neutralised, and that in itself is not a good enough reason to remove the flexibility of a prime minister being able to call an election at their behest and to be the sole person responsible for the calling of the election. It really is a legacy of the English civil war and the reforms of 1688 that it empowers the parliament and the first minister of that parliament, of that cabinet.

Another argument is, of course, to bring Australia in line with the states. I'll talk about that further. Another argument is that the business community likes stability and it likes certainty, and that's true. For investment decisions, the business community does not like the prospect of hung parliaments or elections mid-term that might change prime ministers and governments unexpectedly. But again, I would argue that the business community has prospered quite well for 125 years under three-year unfixed terms, and there's no hard evidence—or at least I haven't seen any hard evidence—that a four-year fixed term would increase certainty of business investment.

Now, the most impressive argument for four-year terms, and a very hard one to negate, is the fact that it is popular. The recent Australian election study by Sarah Cameron and others of Griffith University found that 42 per cent of Australians this year approve of four-year terms. That's one of the highest, if not the highest, I've ever

seen. Thirty per cent are opposed and 28 per cent are of no opinion. However, that's a plural majority, not an absolute majority, so many of those of no opinion may plump for no change. We know that people who are uncertain in referenda do plump for no change.

What are some reasons why people might be moving towards four-year terms? It might be that the last parliament was a hive of electoral activity. We had the referendum as well as various state and two federal elections in three years. A lot of Australians do feel that the act of voting itself is something onerous, that they've got to take their kids to sport on a Saturday morning. That's why prepoll voting is so popular—that's one less thing they have to do on a Saturday. And as outrageous as it might sound to us, there are some Australians who think, 'Goodness me, I don't like to vote.' So that might be one.

There's also the idea of playing politics. In Queensland, unexpectedly, the four-year term got up in the 2016 referendum despite the fact that it lost in 1991 and despite the fact we don't have a legislative council, so it gave the government an extra year of unchecked accountability. The reason was because, at the very precise moment Queensland had the 2016 referendum, Malcolm Turnbull—I'm not saying this is true but this is the perception—was perceived to be playing politics around election timing. That seemed to annoy a lot of people and that probably pushed people into a small majority support for that referendum.

Let me quickly go into the reasons why I think we should keep the three years. One is I believe in the sovereignty of the parliament, and I'm always wary of too much executive authority. We've already seen over the years a growth in executive authority—the growth in regulation, ordnance, subordinate legislation, ministerial directives. But we must remember, Australia remains a parliamentary democracy, and we do have a sovereign parliament checked only by the High Court. It is not as sovereign as the British parliament, but the sovereignty of the parliament is designed to supersede the sovereignty of the executive.

I see four-year terms as a double-edged sword. Yes, cabinets can enjoy freedom to govern for an extra year, but that freedom can sometimes turn into hubris and can extend executive arrogance. We see this often. Again, I'm a Queensland political scientist, so I see it most in Queensland from both sides of politics. A second reason that I'm worried about extending the term of parliament is that Australians still mistrust government and political institutions. That trust has improved by a few percentage points in recent years, but 68 per cent of Australians do not trust politics and politicians, and only 32 per cent say they can trust their local MP. I know this conflicts with the view that 42 per cent want four-year terms, but my view is that, if people are suspicious—and they are. They're not just sceptical of politicians; they're cynical. If we have an unpopular or patently bad government and we've got very suspicious and conspiracy minded types of people who feel that their opportunity to vent their electoral spleen is too far away, they may engage in antidemocratic—or at least antisocial—protest behaviours up to and including violence. So the more opportunity we give voters to express their electoral distaste for an incumbent government, the better. That is my operating principle. 'Frequent elections mean a better democracy' is my operating principle.

The third argument, which can be mitigated perhaps by some tinkering around the Constitution, is that lengthening the term of the House would necessarily lengthen the term of the Senate. Notwithstanding the fact that New South Wales and South Australia have eight-year terms for legislative councillors, I think a lot of Australians would balk at the idea of eight-year terms for senators for the same reasons that I've just talked about.

Lastly—and this is perhaps the least discussed and most difficult to understand reason why I support three-year terms—it's sometimes a good thing that Canberra does things differently from the states. One of the hallmarks of a federal system is that we have a countervailing force—a counterbalance. Is it really in our interest if Canberra and the states do everything identically? The big argument is that we need to bring Canberra in line with the states—four-year fixed terms. I'm not sure that's in the spirit of federalism. Sometimes it's a good thing that Canberra and the states are at odds, because it is a balance of interests. If my history serves me well, I believe that Gough Whitlam at one time floated the idea of having local, state and federal elections—including for both houses of the state and federal parliaments—held on the same day. I'm not sure that's a good idea, because it could lead to flavour-of-the-month politics. That's one reason why we have proportional representation in the Senate. You don't necessarily want the flavour of the month winning the House and the flavour of the month cleaning up the Senate as well. It's a good idea to have points of conflict, or sites of conflict, in Australian politics, including in the parliament. In short, I think it's healthy that Canberra and the states sometimes do politics differently.

I'll move very quickly to say I am a great supporter of expanding the House of Representatives. I won't bore you with the stats, but, in 1984, we had about 67,000 voters per member; today, we've got about 120,000. If we were to use the 1984 formula, we'd have to blow out the House to 268 members. Nobody in Australia is going to accept that, so my argument would be to have an ongoing benchmark for further redistributions going forward.

Aim to have 100,000 voters per member—per seat. If we used that formula today, it would increase the House substantially, but not unwisely, to 180 seats—an increase of 30—and I think that figure would be more publicly acceptable. It's been 40 years since our most significant increase.

However, this creates a constitutional problem. Section 24, the nexus provision, means that the Senate would have to increase to, what, 88 seats in order to be half the size of the House of Representatives, which in turn lowers the quota to be elected. I know that this is a problem. I'm not a great fan of low quotas. I'm not a great fan—at state level, for example—of the whole of a state voting as one electorate to elect a legislative council. I think the quotas should be kept at a reasonable level in order to remove, or keep out, the most extreme fringe dwellers from Australian politics. I know this is outside the scope of the committee, but I would love to see Australia revisit the 1967 referendum question where we tried to break the nexus. I think we need to remove the nexus between the House and the Senate. But, again, if it didn't win in '67, when Australia was very buoyed by the First Nations referendum, it's hardly going to succeed today. But that is my firm view—that Australia needs to break section 24.

Very quickly—I'm sorry to belabour the point—I have a couple of points to make about the reform of safety. I did actually make a submission years ago; I think it was to a state parliamentary committee. In it, I did flag the potential for increased violence and acrimony at polling stations because party workers were increasingly setting up camp outside polling booths earlier and earlier. This is before prepoll voting. People are setting up at 5 pm on the Friday afternoon, and if they pilfer 90 per cent of a school fence, that's going to create antipathy from other campaign workers. So it needs to be systematised; it needs to be regulated. I think exactly how long it can be—how many metres of bunting, how many corflutes can be displayed; that type of thing—needs to be mandated in legislation.

Also, in terms of party workers, we did see an ugly incident in the Hinchinbrook by-election in Queensland, unfortunately. There was no violence, fortunately, but, certainly, again, it was not in the spirit of Australian democracy. I think it's necessary that booth captains or candidates supply names of approved and registered campaign workers to returning officers and that only those people be allowed to work on polling stations. Maybe even have a party worker's Christian name on their shirt so that, if there is any untoward behaviour, that person might be more easily identified.

I don't have great fears. I don't think Australia is going to go down the path of the American type of violence, but there's no doubt that we are seeing a more polarised community and that we are seeing more scuffles at polling stations, which is deeply unfortunate.

CHAIR: Thank you, Professor Williams. Members, we've got a pretty tight timeline, so, if you can, try to keep it to one question, as will I. But we'll have a little bit of flexibility to push into the break as we go on. I'll ask one or two questions about expanding parliament, Professor Williams. Do you think population growth is enough of a reason to push for an expansion of parliament?

Dr Williams: It is for people like you and me, because we know, but it's not for the elector in the pub. It doesn't necessarily pass the pub test. I did sort of say amusingly that, if you mention it at a barbecue, you'll be shouted down. I don't get asked to many barbecues anymore!

CHAIR: Can you think of any reasons that it would pass the pub test or the barbecue test?

Dr Williams: When you explain to them, 'Didn't you just complain to me last week that you can never get hold of a politician? Didn't you just say that you only see politicians at election time? Don't you think more representation would be better representation? Wouldn't you like to be able to get an appointment anytime you email your politician?' That's the sort of argument I've found is very useful. So I think it depends how you frame it. But you're quite right; the first thing people say is: 'Politicians are overpaid and underworked, and there are too many of them. As a matter of fact, politicians should work for free.' I've had people say that to me, and then you have to explain to them that only millionaires would be able to be in parliament—'Oh! I'd never thought of that.' So, if you explain it, I think you can win them over on the population argument—that 'more' equals 'better representation'.

CHAIR: I'll come back to that if we've got time. Deputy Chair.

Senator COLBECK: I'll try to combine my three questions into one. I'll go to a different topic, but it's related. You talked about a threshold for entry.

Dr Williams: Yes, that's right.

Senator COLBECK: The increase in the Senate would reduce the threshold from 16.7 to 14.3, if it went to 14. Do you think there is a reasonable balance for Senate representation? I'm curious about where you think a reasonable threshold for entry might be.

Dr Williams: That's a good question.

Senator COLBECK: What is a reasonable balance for Senate representation across the size of the Senate and what is the perspective on the territories, because you leave the territories at two in your submission?

Dr Williams: As far as I'm aware—I'm not an expert on territory politics—the territory populations don't seem to be exploding. So at this point, I would suggest that two senators for each territory is probably still sufficient. But I think the 14.3 threshold we've got today for a half-Senate election is about right. It's low enough to include genuine minor parties, I think. We've cleaned up the loophole that the preference whisperer had, and I think that numbering six squares across the top of the ballot paper has sorted that out somewhat. It's still not perfect. You can talk to people like Malcolm Mackerras—he still doesn't think that's perfect. So I think the 14.3 per cent, or the 7.7 per cent for a double dissolution, is about right. Seven point seven is too low, but, hey, that's what comes with a double dissolution. You just have to put up with it. I think if it drops to 12.5 with 14 senators, which is 6.25 for a double dissolution, that's getting dangerously low. I've had many people ask me, 'How did this person get elected?' especially when they've looked at their personal vote. They might only get something like 40 votes below the line, and they've been elected on a small threshold.

Senator COLBECK: Have a squiz at Tassie.

CHAIR: Senator Mulholland.

Senator MULHOLLAND: My question relates to your submission around polling booth reforms. We've heard a lot of evidence about antisocial behaviour and growing angst on polling booths. You've got a couple of suggestions there around signage—around limiting the time when signage can be erected and the amount of signage—and also around registering volunteers and name tags. Could you talk about the Queensland parliament experience of the limiting of signage? That was obviously a reform that came in—

Dr Williams: To be honest, it's been a long time since I've looked at that legislation, so I'm not sure if it has actually been mandated in the act. It has?

Senator MULHOLLAND: Yes.

Dr Williams: Alright. You know more about it than me.

Senator MULHOLLAND: At the moment, it's on the day of the election, at sunrise.

Dr Williams: On polling day.

Senator MULHOLLAND: So it can be at five or 6 am that signage is allowed to go up, and it's only two signs per entry. A-frames and bunting are illegal in Queensland under those changes. And some of the other states have moved that way as well. It's interesting that there was an incident at Hinchinbrook by-election, which you mentioned. I wonder whether or not that has helped. We have heard a bit of evidence around influxes of volunteers at polling booths—that people don't know who they are or where they've come from. They're wearing shirts et cetera. So I'm quite interested in your recommendation around registering volunteers. The parties themselves obviously have a list of who's who and the numbers at prepoll and the polling booths, but the AEC doesn't.

Dr Williams: Exactly.

Senator MULHOLLAND: I'm quite interested in the concept of providing that information to the AEC and registering volunteers. Perhaps, the next step is a name badge. I suppose people will have a different view about that. I invite you to make a few more comments there.

Dr Williams: I haven't thought through all the logistics of it, but in an extreme form, there might even be background checks. I know that's sort of infringing on people's rights to participate in the democratic process, but, if we ever got into an era where we had violence at every election, obviously that would be a requirement.

I think it would just send the right message to political parties to make sure they're only choosing people who represent them well and that they can trust, if they know that these names are going to be scrutinised, if they know that these names are going to be not just among party members but among returning officials of the ECQ in Queensland or the ACE in Australia. I think it formalises the process. If it's formal, it tends to make people behave a little better.

Senator MULHOLLAND: It takes the anonymity away from being a person in a particular coloured shirt.

Dr Williams: It does. We've all heard about busloads of people being bussed in to do all sorts of things. That's not a new phenomenon; that happened in the 1980s. But I think it formalises it and it keeps everyone on their best behaviour.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Thank you.

CHAIR: Dr Ryan.

Dr RYAN: I'm interested in your thoughts around how we can successfully prosecute changes to the Constitution by a referendum, given that's something which traditionally, unless there is bipartisan support, has proved very difficult in Australia.

Dr Williams: That's a really good question. There has to be bipartisan support no doubt. I suspect—again, you would know better than me—that four-year terms could have bipartisan support. I suspect that most politicians would like four-year terms for the lower house because campaigning can be onerous. It's expensive and it's onerous, especially summer elections, when people are traipsing around in suits et cetera. It's not fun. So I get it. And for electors too: that's why we don't have January elections. People don't want their cricket and tennis interrupted. It's not necessarily a fun thing for the voter.

Until we get bipartisan support, there's no chance of breaking the nexus. The first thing they would say is, 'If you're expanding the House, that's more politicians.' I'm a great advocate of returning a legislative council to Queensland, for example. I've campaigned for years for this. A lot of people say, 'We don't need extra politicians.' What I say is: 'We could actually have three fewer politicians if we had 60 in the legislative assembly and 30 in the legislative council. That's actually three fewer than we've got now.' By selling it as, 'We'd actually get fewer senators, or at least we'd get no more senators than we've got now,' that might be a selling point. It's not necessarily about more politicians on the public purse.

But you're quite right. If we did have a referendum on four-year terms today, it probably would pass, just. If we had a referendum on breaking the nexus without a very long build-up, it probably would fail. It would be probably a close finish even if it had bipartisan support. Again, the Australian electorate tends to, if they don't understand, vote no. That seems to be the position. For example, if Anthony Albanese were considering that today, that's a referendum for the next term. It would need so much lead-up that you couldn't even have it this term. You're talking years of preparation, and yet I think it's one of the most essential things. The Constitution is crying out for reform, and we can't do anything substantial to the House until we tackle the nexus question.

Dr RYAN: Thank you.

CHAIR: Mr Neumann.

Mr NEUMANN: I'm interested in your perspective on truth in advertising. South Australia has got a truth-in-advertising arrangement.

Dr Williams: They do, yes.

Mr NEUMANN: The AEC has always seemed to be historically a bit reluctant to get involved in this federally. I'm interested in your perspective on that and how that might change the tone of political campaigns. In the last campaign we saw more outrageous corflutes and billboards and signage than I've ever seen before, certainly in Queensland and certainly in my electorate, so I'm interested in what you have to say about that.

Dr Williams: I'm a passionate supporter of the South Australian legislation, and I think that Australia does need truth-in-advertising laws. I've written a couple of newspaper columns about this. Again, it's a parenthood statement. It's a very brave person who says, 'I don't want truth in political advertising.' You can't sell aspirin as an anticancer drug, and yet somehow you're allowed to sell an election policy as a pro-employment policy when it's not. So I'm a great supporter of it.

How far does it go? Obviously, I'm not a lawyer, so exactly how do you write that bill? What constitutes an untruth and what constitutes a truth? How far you go is obviously a matter for the lawyers and a matter for the courts. Will it change the tone? I think it would. I think it would tone it down. Yes, we've seen some egregious campaigning in the past—again, Menzies and the anticommunism campaign of the 1950s—but it seems that it's become more egregious in just the last decade or so since social media. It's to the point where it's become a water-cooler topic. We're still in the infancy of social media and digital communication. Imagine what it's going to be like in 20 or 50 years time, again, with the proliferation of AI. It'd be very difficult for the uninformed or what we call the low-information voter to be able to discriminate between fact and opinion, so I think we need to look at this sooner rather than later.

I'm surprised—I think most Australians would be surprised—that all the states and the Commonwealth don't have this legislation. But, again, it's a matter of the exact wording of it. What would pass the test of the High Court if you don't want to infringe on political communication? We talk about political communication rather than free speech. That's obviously a difficult one, but I think certainly it would be welcome. It would be welcomed by the Australian electorate. Probably the biggest—not the only but probably the biggest—breaches of the spirit of truth in advertising are the fringe parties. Yes, the major parties tell porkies as well, but the fringe

parties tend to use it as stock-in-trade. That's part of populism—the politics of exaggeration. It just might encourage those parties to pull their horns in.

Mr NEUMANN: And the AEC is the appropriate person to supervise it?

Dr Williams: It would have to be through the AEC. It shouldn't be just one person. It should be a panel of lawyers to read and vet each complaint and sieve it through the act to see if it does breach the act. So it couldn't even be laypersons. It needs to be a panel of lawyers, I think.

Mr NEUMANN: Thanks.

CHAIR: Mr Caldwell.

Mr CALDWELL: Associate Professor, thanks for being here. In relation to the expansion of parliament, we obviously talked and focused a lot on just the sheer numbers of it. Given that you mentioned 68 per cent of people don't have a great deal of faith in their politicians et cetera, to go from something that would be like 120,000 per electorate to 100,000, I just did a quick back-of-the-napkin calculation of what an MP costs. It could be like $1.5 million to $2 million when you put it all together. Do you think it becomes a very hard argument to say that there's a value-for-money proposition—

Dr Williams: It does.

Mr CALDWELL: to say we're going to add 30. They're going to cost $2 million each. That's $60 million recurrent. Do you think there's a way that you could sell the value proposition outside of—

Dr Williams: You're quite right. If you just fronted up and said, 'Guess what? We're increasing the size of the House by 30 members,' Facebook and Twitter would melt down. So it needs to be sold in a way such as, 'The quality of representation is lacking.' Lacking is probably too strong a word. The quality of representation is at its limit. It's strained. If you want better representation, we need more representation. This is the Australian parliament working for you. I often say to people that the parliament doesn't belong to the politicians; it belongs to the people. Their chests blow out about that. 'Ooh, it's my parliament.' They feel empowered. If you sell those two things together in a binary, it is possible. Again, politicians asking for more politicians is not going to pass the pub test. You do need authoritative third parties to say, 'Yes, what they're saying is actually true.'

Mr CALDWELL: Thank you.

CHAIR: Mr Burnell.

Mr BURNELL: Thank you, Associate Professor. I just wanted to go back to the fixed-term discussion that you opened with in your opening statement. One of the consistent issues that are met by voters is the inability to have access-friendly prepolling and polling sites, the lack of toilets for volunteers and the lack of parking, creating frustrated voters et cetera. So is there merit in going to a three-year fixed term? If we don't have fixed terms, what's the workaround to get better surety around location selection for both prepolling and polling sites?

Dr Williams: I would certainly accede to three-year fixed terms rather than four-year fixed terms. I think that is an eminently sellable point to the public because it's not granting the executive another year of power and it is removing the opportunism of the prime minister of the day. So I think that may well be a model that turns up, and I would certainly support that as my second. I'm still in favour of prime ministerial discretion because I'm a political historian and I think the roots of Westminster have served us well, but, if I had to concede, a three-year fixed term would probably serve both camps well.

A big part of that might be offering the certainty of facilities around elections. I know that electoral commissions white-knuckle it in the days when they think, 'Is there going to be an election called?' They're on standby. It's a very difficult time for senior AEC or ECQ staff, wondering when the next election is going to be. There's a lot of work to be done. They put in a lot of weekends to get up to speed. If it were fixed, those certainties could be taken out. They would know when they're going to have to print several million ballot papers. They would know when they're going to have to publish materials on the web and do public information campaigns. They would know even down to the prosaic things, such as getting sun shelters and portable toilets and parking spaces for prepoll stations. So that is a very persuasive argument. As I said, if push came to shove, I'd happily accede to three-year fixed terms.

Mr BURNELL: Thank you.

CHAIR: Ms Campbell.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you, Dr Williams, for giving evidence today. In terms of your advocacy for the expansion of the parliament, I wanted to ask what you thought the impact of that kind of structural reform would have on the diversity of the parliament. Do you believe it would be more or less reflective of what our community

looks like today? In terms of diversity, what impact do you think that the regulatory changes that you're suggesting around volunteers would have on participation?

Dr Williams: They're really good questions. The expansion of the House would not, in and of itself, increase diversity. We know that MPs and senators are preselected, so parties act as gatekeepers in providing their own diversity. However, an expanded parliament does at least offer the opportunity for increased diversity, simply because you can imagine the hullabaloo if you were saying, 'We're going to shrink the House of Representatives by 30 members.' What a bunfight there would be for the remaining seats! Those who might be seen as 'other' Australian—outside someone who looks like an MP—might struggle to keep their foothold in the legislature. It certainly offers the opportunity, but, ultimately, we know that the parties are the gatekeepers of who represents them and diversity.

I take your point also about regulation around party campaign workers on polling day and on booths. For example, it could—not necessarily, but it could—impact the differently abled. It shouldn't have to. It could, but it shouldn't have to. It might affect people who might be partially sighted or have difficulties walking, if there are certain restrictions around requirements of duties, but I think that's probably at the margins. I think that's probably pushing the envelope a little bit too much. It shouldn't. Again, I don't think the regulation in and of itself would restrict the diversity of party workers. Certainly, the expansion of the parliament wouldn't necessarily restrict it. It offers the opportunity, but it's up to the parties to seek diversity.

CHAIR: Thank you, Paul. We might have some questions on notice. Deputy Chair, will you put some in writing?

Senator COLBECK: No, I'll ask quickly and you can take it on notice. You've come up with a number of 100,000. I'm curious to know where that number comes from, if there's any globally—

Dr Williams: I think it would be a saleable number. It's a round number; it's a saleable number.

CHAIR: In a retail sense?

Dr Williams: You could sell it to the public.

Senator COLBECK: I get that. You've obviously looked at electoral systems globally. Are there any comparisons that we could make?

Dr Williams: It's slightly larger than the British. Obviously, they have 459, so it's larger than the British constituency. It is an arbitrary figure that I picked, but 100,000 would be a sellable number, I think.

Senator COLBECK: In terms of what's manageable for an MP, is there anything out there that might be of use?

Dr Williams: That's a good question. No, I haven't researched that in terms, but I do make the point that I think it would be a very hard case to prosecute that we need to go back to 67,000, when telecommunications are much more efficient today than they were in 1984. I settled on 100,000 not just because it's a round figure that's sellable but because it's a midpoint between '84 and today.

CHAIR: I have one question on notice for you. You mentioned that violence and polarisation are not in the spirit of Australian democracy. I'd love it if you could spend some time defining what the spirit of Australian democracy is from your point of view.

Dr Williams: Goodness! Whole books have been written on that.

CHAIR: We don't need the answer now, because that might take a while, but—

Senator COLBECK: You can toss the spirit of cricket in there as well, if you like!

CHAIR: I'm curious. What is it that we're trying to protect here, from your point of view?

Dr Williams: My eight-second soundbite would be, really, that Australians still believe in the fair go. For example, the fact that you read on Facebook, and elsewhere, people saying: 'I don't like Anthony Albanese. I really don't. But I wish him well in his marriage.' That's the most common comment. You get a lot of trolls who are saying nasty things about Anthony Albanese and his new wife, but a lot of people are saying: 'I don't like Anthony Albanese. I don't vote Labor. But I wish them well.' I think that's still the core Australian spirit, that we can reach across the aisle and have a civil debate, civil discourse, and we believe in a fair go.

CHAIR: And you saw fractures in that at the time—

Dr Williams: I see cracks. I see hairline cracks. It's not fractured yet, but I see hairline cracks.

CHAIR: Thank you. If you've been asked to provide any additional information, please forward it to the secretariat by Friday 9 January 2026. You will be sent a copy of the transcript of your evidence and will have an opportunity to request corrections to any transcription errors. Thanks for your time today. Members, if you do

have any further questions, I think we've got seven days for questions on notice that can be emailed through the secretariat. Thank you very much.

Dr Williams: Thank you for inviting me.

JORDAN, Mr Travis, Private Capacity

[10:39]

CHAIR: I now welcome Mr Travis Jordan. Although the committee does not require you to give evidence under oath, I should advise you that this hearing is a legal proceeding of the parliament and therefore has the same standing as proceedings of the respective houses. The giving of false or misleading evidence is a serious matter and may be regarded as a contempt of parliament. The evidence given today will be recorded by Hansard and attracts parliamentary privilege. I now invite you to make a brief opening statement—potentially not the 70-odd pages that you gave in your very detailed submission—so we can ask a few more questions.

Mr Jordan: Thank you, Chair, and I thank the committee for their invitation to give evidence today. Speaking of many pages, since I provided my submission I've expanded some of those issues into subsequent papers, which I'm happy to table. All these papers build on the idea that we have collectively neglected innovating on, expanding and entrenching our successful representative democracy and the institutions that maintain its success. In doing so, we have diluted everyday people's voice, influence and desire to participate in those institutions.

To fix representative democracy, we need to celebrate the institutions that drive it. There is real resilience in systems that centre parliaments as central sites for expressing and resolving political conflict. Until recently, it was rare to see a think tank report, a government discussion paper or even an advocacy campaign talking about the connectedness between elected representatives and everyday voters, about the critical role political parties play in our electoral democracy, and about the role active political participation—embodied, for example, in the ritual of election day—has in maintaining social cohesion.

These issues were forgotten for some good reasons. Our institutions have stood the test of time and—even now, amid growing illiberalism, demagoguery and populism in other like democracies—Australia remains stable, strong and liberal. The cracks, however, are showing. Like in those other democracies, trust in our democracy is slipping. This is especially true of younger people—a ticking demographic clock for our democracy. The wider the gulf grows between everyday representatives, their parties, and everyday people, the bigger the risk that we start on the same slide away from high-trust democracy we've seen globally.

Thinking about parliament is the first step. We acknowledge that the value of people's votes is too diluted in the House and that it makes being a good representative harder, it makes connecting with voters harder, and it makes malapportionment worse. To that end, in my submission, I modelled five futures for this parliament, projecting population growth for the next 40 years—roughly the time, if history is anything to go by, that we'll be having this discussion again. These models let us predict when we'll be having the discussions about workload, disconnection and voter distance that triggered this review, and the same ones that triggered the reviews in 1948 and 1983.

It's also worth noting at this point that neither of those expansions were bipartisan, so lack of will from the opposition, or the potential for this necessary reform to be weaponised at the next election, should not be a reason to delay it. In the interest of avoiding that exact fight in another 40 years, I propose a legislative mechanism to automatically increase the size of parliament in line with population growth, such that the constitutionally guaranteed five seats for Tasmania will never again cause malapportionment in the House.

But parliament is just the first step. Restoring voice and participation in our institutions cannot stop at the ballot box. That's why I explore four other policy directions in my paper that recentre people in the rest of our political institutions and rebuild trust in our democracy. They might seem too bold for how early in the crisis we find ourselves, but our strong institutions create exactly the conditions for us to experiment. We shouldn't use our privileged position as an excuse to not innovate; we should see it as our duty to use the advantages to test innovations that other countries more vulnerable to political disruption can't. We can take risks others can't afford to, and we have a moral obligation to do so.

I would like to briefly touch on the question that has already been raised around knock-on effects on staffing and budgets from any parliamentary expansion. Whether it's from salaries, new officers, the cost of conducting additional elections or even remodelling the parliament itself, any expansion will have significant budgetary effects. The PBO estimated that each new MP or senator costs around $1.9 million per year, based on existing office expenses, staffing allocations and discretionary budgets. But maintaining the status quo also costs money. The additional staffing resource granted to MPs in 2023 cost nearly $40 million a year, equivalent to 21 more politicians with a full staffing complement and office. These complex workforce questions, however, are best dealt with by people other than those of us who are interested in the conduct of the elections themselves and should be deferred to an independent inquiry, separate from politicians.

That's why, in my submission, I recommend the questions around staffing allocations be managed by the independent Remuneration Tribunal, a power that it used to have. Given that the body routinely conducts reviews of MPs' workloads in comparison with those of other jurisdictions and the private sector in order to decide their pay and entitlements, they're best placed to consider these factors in relation to staffing and budgets, both right now and after any expansion.

CHAIR: Thank you, Mr Jordan. We really appreciate the amount of time and effort you've put into your submission. You mentioned, as part of the 'composition of parliament' section, 'increasing the size of parliament and its impact on rural electorates'. Could you expand on that. Would you see it as a benefit for rural electorates or a hindrance?

Mr Jordan: This is a repeated thing that we see at federal, state and even in local councils. Populations of our urban centres are growing significantly faster than rural and regional areas. Some regional cities are growing at a reasonable rate, but rural areas, especially, like western Queensland, aren't. There was a risk, for example, in the current Queensland redistribution that one of the four very large rural electorates may be abolished, effectively disenfranchising a large proportion of rural voters. It also means they have no effective community of interest, because what does someone in a Blackall have in common with someone in Townsville?

In that sense, we're dealing with these electorates that potentially have 180,000 people in them. In rural areas that could be half the state, if not more. The point of the House is to provide local representation and to bring local issues and idiosyncrasies to Canberra. An MP isn't able to do that if they're representing such a large geographic area that they can't even physically get around the electorate. Bob Katter famously has a pilot's licence for that reason. In that sense, yes, I think any sort of expansion would improve things for rural electorates, the caveat being there's no sign that their population shifts towards urban areas are going to decline or change over time, so this issue will re-emerge in only a few years if we don't make a significant change in the number of MPs.

CHAIR: You touched on some of the rural seats that are being diluted by the city suburbs where, perhaps, a lot of land mass of the seat would be in rural and regional Australia, but the population is sort of in one corner. Do you think it's important that the parliament seeks to maintain representation from areas that are more defined, in terms of being rural, regional, urban or peri-urban, or is that sort of mixture a better form of representation?

Mr Jordan: I'm not necessarily in favour of a hard border. That being said, there is a point where people in different geographies have different priorities. There is a risk that, especially in the majoritarian, single-member districts that we have in the House, you end up with a larger proportion of your electorate feeling disenfranchised, whether those are the regional areas being diluted by the peri-urban and suburban areas of the nearby regional city or, on the flip side, if you only have a few of those suburbs included in a large rural area and those suburban voters are represented by a very rural focused MP.

CHAIR: Thanks. Deputy Chair.

Senator COLBECK: I'm a little bit interested in the same thing. An increase in the size of the parliament, because it's based on population, is actually going to concentrate representation into urbanised areas, which would further disenfranchise regional Australia because that's where the population is. How do you actually balance that?

Mr Jordan: I think there's a risk that it might happen anyway. If we don't increase parliament then, with continued urbanisation, these rural seats will become more and more diluted by the suburbs of cities.

Senator COLBECK: Border-secure, I suppose.

Mr Jordan: There's a risk that they'll disappear entirely and there'll be no representation for rural areas.

Senator COLBECK: Going to the question that I asked the previous witnesses, do you think that there is either a spatial or a numerical voter quota that provides the best outcome in a democratic sense?

Mr Jordan: I think, as a broad principle, we should aim for a one vote/one value between jurisdictions to avoid malapportionment—I obviously used Tasmania as the benchmark in my submission. We also want to ideally balance that somewhat over time to avoid people feeling like their votes are being devalued. There was a very robust study in 2023 called *On the optimal size of legislatures*. It was a descriptive study that compared hundreds of assemblies around the world at a national and subnational level, both federal and bicameral jurisdictions. It controlled for those to work out whether there is a natural inclination for assemblies to grow. It found that, over time, the number of elected representatives in any given parliament grows at a rate of around 42 per cent of population growth. The implication is that higher populations overall tend towards higher population-to-representative ratios. To give you an example, Australia's population has grown by roughly 70 per cent since the last expansion, so, by this descriptive metric, you'd expect parliament to have grown by about 30 per cent by now, to follow that 48-52 split. That is effectively the third future I have modelled—the Hawke-Beasley reforms,

or the third of the five. But it's also worth noting that's off a much higher base population in 1983, even among bicameral federal jurisdictions. So, while there is a descriptive tendency to increase, if we followed that increase now, we would still by global standards be underrepresented, according to this study.

CHAIR: Senator Mulholland?

Senator MULHOLLAND: Thank you, Mr Jordan, for joining us today. I want to come to your five scenarios modelling a potential increase to the parliament. You've landed on the recommendation around subsequently growing the House of Representatives from 150 members to 222. That would be about a 50 per cent increase for the House. Then you recommend increasing the number of senators from 12 per state to 18 and the number of territory senators from two to three. I know you go through a range of scenarios, talking about one vote, one value, with the Tasmanian rule. One of the pieces of evidence we have consistently heard through this inquiry has been the challenge particularly in the comparison between the population in the ACT and the population in Tasmania. I apologise to my Tasmanian colleague on the committee! My question is: in moving from two to three as the recommended position you've landed on, looking at all those scenarios, we're still in a situation where the ACT has a population just over 450,000 and Tasmania has a population of 581,000. It's a minimal increase from two to three in the ACT. They'd have 18 down in Tasmania and three in the ACT. Obviously, the Constitution has a view about the states, House et cetera. Could you talk me through that conundrum? That's the main example—Tasmania versus the ACT—of concerns about disparity in representation.

Mr Jordan: In the first instance, the design in the Constitution of the Senate means we're never going to avoid the malapportionment between states. Simply put, Tasmania has never shown and shows no inclination to grow at the same rate as the rest of the country. There will always be this problem, which is why I suggest the mechanism. I settled on three because that's what the last committee recommended. My personal view is that three is too low for the reasons that Ben Raue goes into quite a lot of detail on around competitiveness of the elections. That being said, for a very novel alternative, the two territories together equal roughly the population of Tasmania, and there's suggestion, based on the ABS population projections, that they'll overtake together Tasmania in only a few years. Potentially, you could apportion senators, or at least a half-Senate allocation, between the territories based on their proportionate population. In that sense, you would essentially have five senators for the ACT and four senators for the Northern Territory if you expanded to, for example, 18 senators, or, by the same token, four senators for the ACT and three senators for the Northern Territory if you expanded to 14 senators. That is an alternative way of doing this. I have no strong opinions other than believing territory voters should have competitive Senate elections and that, broadly, our elections should reflect the diversity of voters preferences, which, in very small magnitudes, whether that's a single member in the House or whether that's two members in an ACT election, don't effectively capture the diversity of the opinions of the electorate and the priorities therein.

Dr RYAN: Mr Jordan, we were asking questions earlier around referenda. What are your thoughts on a referendum and whether or not the potential for success of a referendum is related to the length of terms?

Mr Jordan: My personal view on the length of terms is that I don't believe it’s a compelling reason to have four-year terms. Personally, I'd probably campaign against it in a referendum. That being said, the public opinion polling and research we've seen suggest that people are broadly sympathetic to the idea that longer terms allow for better governance. Again, I've not seen a lot of compelling evidence that that's the case. I agree with Professor Williams that more elections are better in terms of giving voters an opportunity to kick out people they feel aren't performing well. I would also say that, as others have discussed, a three-year fixed term is doable without a referendum. The Prime Minister could decide today to announce when the next election is and set a precedent for future prime ministers to announce on the day after the election when the next one will be. That's entirely within the realm of possibility, and, as Ben Raue has shown in his blog, the frequency with which we have irregular elections, elections that don't fall within the regular pattern of when we have them, has diminished over time to the point where we practically have three-year fixed terms already; we just do it informally.

CHAIR: Mr Neumann.

Mr NEUMANN: On page 41 of your submission, you talk about fewer people joining political parties. Political participation levels might have dropped off in terms of people's participation in political parties, but political activity is maintained at the same level. We still have local, state and federal elections. We still have 150 people in the House of Representatives and half that number in the Senate. What are the implications of the drop-off in political participation in political parties for what happens on polling booths and participation in activities? People who join political parties, particularly major political parties, often get trained or schooled. They have scrutineers' school to show you how to operate. We see that with long-term Independents as well, crossbenchers who've been there a while and have systems in place to train up their staff—'This is how you'll behave; this is

what you'll wear; this is what you'll do.' What are the implications of our political discourse on the decline of political representation and involvement in political parties?

Mr Jordan: I go into a lot of detail in a piece about rebuilding Australia's political parties and reconnecting everyday voters with our parties.

Mr NEUMANN: Is there a link to citizenship education?

Mr Jordan: These things are all connected. The most direct connection is that the research we have on the reason people don't join political parties is the same as the reason they feel like they don't get a say at elections, which is that they feel like they don't have a voice or that their say doesn't influence the outcome. Whether that is joining a political party or casting a vote, that is the overwhelming feeling for why people don't participate or feel like their participation was wasted.

On the discourse question, I'll see if I can dig up the quote. There was a former Liberal senator, way back in the early nineties, who had a quote around, 'The only people who join political parties these days are the careerists and the weirdos.' There is a risk that, if we become more and more disconnected from everyday people, whether that is activists or members, then we become—I don't want to adopt the term inappropriately—an echo chamber, where we reinforce each other's worst behaviours because we're seeking an objective that is out of step with community expectations. I think that's a bigger risk the further away from the central authority of the party you get, because obviously MPs are very connected with their electorates. But if you go down to the grassroots, especially in insurgent campaigns where there maybe isn't an incumbent MP, there is a risk that the campaign is led by people who maybe don't represent the common values locally and that the campaign will take on a distasteful flavour.

Mr NEUMANN: And the link to citizenship education?

Mr Jordan: There is a space for civics education. There's a lifelong space for civics education. One of the things that the last inquiry missed a little bit was that it is important in schools but there are a lot of people—you all would have experienced it—who may have last engaged with civics education 20 or 30 years ago, and so maybe their idea of voting works is out of step or their idea of what's allowed in booths is out of step with what the election is. Obviously, we're all political nerds. We all know what the different rules around different elections are. That isn't commonly known to average voters nor should they be expected to know. I make the case elsewhere in my submission that, broadly, we should be aligning rules between jurisdictions because it makes things more tractable to voters and it reduces that feeling of dissonance. We came to the Queensland example before where we had three elections in 18 months, and each of those elections had wildly different rules around signage and booth behaviour, and the different third-parties were involved. But for a lot of voters, they understood the difference between the levels of government, but they didn't understand the difference in rules between elections, and that can make election day feel uncomfortable and unpleasant for them.

I will take this opportunity to briefly comment on the hostility on booths, if that's alright. I raised in my submission how much an impact regulating to restrict one or two very bad actors will have on the vast majority of good actors. I think it's a very hard balance to strike, but, that being said, a lot of the noise, colour and performance on booths, even if it's overwhelming to some voters, is an important part of fostering a ritual on election day and enculturating voting as a civic responsibility, which is a very unique Australian thing. Part of the knock-on effect of compulsory voting is that Australians tend to see voting as a civic responsibility and not a right, which is very different to how European and American voters feel about the value of voting, and that has a big kick-on effect on social cohesion. I'd be really worried about losing that if we overcompensated the regulation to deal with this handful of bad actors.

That being said, on a personal level, I booth-captained those three elections for all of prepoll at city hall just down the street. For six weeks I saw the frontlines of behaviour on booths. I would say that the usual players—parties, unions, environmental campaigns—all played nice. There was no demonstrable hostility increase with them from any other election that I have been involved in. There was one exception. A new third-party organisation emerged with various branded campaigns and a significant presence at the Queensland state election, and it grew again through the federal election. The campaigners from this organisation were incredibly hostile towards volunteers, both mine and those from other organisations including the party they were ostensibly trying to help, and I observed them harass, berate, insult and even inappropriately manhandle members of the public. I understand that ours was a particularly nice booth compared to some of the ones in Melbourne and Western Sydney.

I would not support the exclusion of third-party campaigns from election booths nor any reduction of the number of volunteers allowed when overwhelmingly other organisations are doing the right thing. But, when one

new organisation so blatantly breaks conventions and pushes the limits of rules, I'm sceptical that they wouldn't immediately breach something light touch like the volunteers' code of conduct. There's a risk here which is a classic problem in regulatory design where you have a vast majority of instinctual regulation compliers, which are most political actors, and one very bad actor who's an instinctual regulation avoider. One potential avenue to explore is to require the very explicit disclosure, like authorisation requirements, for when a branded campaign is funded or delivered by another larger organisation as a way to launder or obscure the involvement of that larger organisation.

CHAIR: Mr Caldwell.

Mr CALDWELL: Mr Travis Jordan, thank you for your enthusiasm. I think it's actually incredibly refreshing for us to see someone who's as passionate about this stuff as we are. And congratulations for being a booth captain for three elections. It's a big effort.

Mr Jordan: It was a lot of sunburn.

Mr CALDWELL: I'm also pleased you were here during the evidence that Associate Professor Williams gave, and I'm pleased that you pointed to the PBO data about the cost per MP. That's very useful, thank you. On the expansion of the parliament, there's a significant disproportion between those smaller states and territories. I don't know whether this is a factor, but I'm from the state of Queensland, and a lot of us here today are, and I worry a little about—

CHAIR: There's a malapportioned number of Queenslanders on this—

Mr CALDWELL: That's just how I like it! Is there a chance that the state flavour of the voice in the House of Reps could start to blow out even more between, say, New South Wales and WA or New South Wales and Queensland, over time, because if you reduce the number of voters, you will be starting to increase the number of seats in a heavily populated state like New South Wales. Do you have any thoughts on how that will play out over time? Does that make sense?

Mr Jordan: Yes, it does.

Mr CALDWELL: There's the sentiment of our state representation in the parliament. I know that's supposed to be cured by the Senate, but it's not.

Mr Jordan: Absolutely.

Mr CALDWELL: Does that make sense?

Mr Jordan: I would say, historically, that sense of state solidarity was a lot stronger in both houses. It's a relatively historical anomaly that we have seen a bit of a flattening in that in both houses in the last 30 or 40 years. Some members of the committee have previously been involved with discussions where a state grouping in parliament broke with the broader consensus over an issue that affected their state. I think that's not necessarily a bad thing.

One of the reasons we have the lower house and the House of Representatives is to provide local representation, and state representation is a part of that. They're meant to be a connection between the culture of the local area, and that is both the seat they're in but also the culture of the state and the state government that they deal with. Each of us deal with different levels of government as MPs, politicians, political actors and colleagues in other states do. We have more local knowledge about the issues that are affecting our state and where there are sometimes tensions between states. I don't think it's necessarily a bad thing that parliament reflects that tension.

CHAIR: I suppose you've got the Senate as a stopgap as well for equal representation—

Mr Jordan: In theory.

CHAIR: Yes, that's right. Next, we have Ms Campbell.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you very much. I want to ask if you could take us through the voucher system in your proposal and how that would work. And can you also go over where a similar system or an analogous system has been in place?

Mr Jordan: Of course. I'm again happy to table this longer paper that explores the concept. The major jurisdiction internationally that has this approach is Seattle in the United States. Seattle's model is a bit different to what I propose. I understand Bill Browne from the Australia Institute is a proponent of the pure Seattle model. For those who aren't familiar, the Seattle model works by collecting a dedicated property tax, which is then quarantined for a fund that is then given in vouchers to residents of the city to donate to local candidates during the council election. It's a way, essentially, of changing the way campaign finance is done to not only give

everyone a vote but also a money vote. They can spread that around in a way that they can't with their physical vote.

My proposal is similar in design, but it goes to a different end which is this issue around civic and political participation. Other parties have declined consistently as a proportion of population for 60 years, to the point now where far less than one per cent of the population are a member of a political party. This is a true trend across all aspects of civic and political life, whether that's unions, churches or civic organisations. Even participation in council elections have slowly declined in areas where that has not been compulsory. Obviously, that's attenuated by how close it is to other elections.

My proposal is to set up a voucher system where everyday voters would get an opportunity to join any democratic organisation, whether it's a political party, a campaigning vehicle for an independent or a union as a non-industrial member. They could even get up a generalised campaigning organisation, provided they're internally democratically organised and are committed to a commitment to our constitution and good democracy.

My proposal is to cap that at about $60 per person on the electoral roll per year, which—assuming about a 10 per cent uptake, which is about the max we would expect in any voluntary scheme like this—is about $110 million a year, completely supplanting the current funding arrangement for political parties, which is about $52 million per year. The trade-off would be—at the moment, political parties largely receive this large amount of public funding for very little public benefit. There is a public benefit in political parties' existing, but, as Katz and Mair explore in their cartel party thesis, parties will sometimes pass legislation for their own benefit rather than for the benefit of everyday voters. Shocking!

This would essentially increase the amount of money that parties would get, in exchange for their meeting internal governance, transparency and democratic organisation minimums, including guaranteeing that anyone who used this scheme would get equal voting rights and an opportunity to engage in policy and strategy decisions in that organisation. It would also create a dedicated opportunity to provide promotional nudges that encourage uptake in active participation in general—reminders for participants to go to events, vote in elections and take part in civic debates—because part of the obligation to have a voucher system is the obligation on the state to communicate to everyday voters that a voucher exists.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you.

CHAIR: Mr Jordan, to clarify, you mentioned a study on the optimal size of assemblies. I'm assuming it's all in the footnotes of your—

Mr Jordan: It is. I can provide that on notice as well.

CHAIR: Thank you. And, to clarify, would your database of election day material include material to be handed out and displayed at prepoll, or would it just be for election day?

Mr Jordan: I would have to double-check to see what the Victorian system is. I think my suggestion would be to effectively have two separate lodgement dates: you would lodge for prepoll and then you could lodge later—maybe a couple of days in advance of election day—for election day.

CHAIR: Would that be locked? If you lodged for something for prepoll—say it has to be lodged by the Friday before—that would mean you couldn't display or hand out anything else through the duration of prepoll.

Mr Jordan: That's right.

CHAIR: You would then have to lodge something else for election day.

Mr Jordan: Yes, and there might be extenuating circumstances as to why you would need to change something being handed out at prepoll. Things change in two weeks or, potentially, three or four weeks, depending on what the timeline is. But that would be an extraordinary circumstance, and it would be up to whichever organisation were managing that database to deal with whether that circumstance would be an adequate reason to change what is being handed out or not.

CHAIR: Thank you, Mr Jordan, for your attendance. If you've been asked to provide any additional information, please forward it to the secretariat by Friday 9 January. You may receive questions on notice from us within seven days. You'll be sent a copy of the transcript of your evidence, and we'll have an opportunity to request corrections to any transcription errors. Thank you so much for your time not only today but in preparing your multiple submissions.

HALL, Ms Emi, Director, Operations, Foundations for Tomorrow

[11:13]

CHAIR: Welcome. Although the committee does not require you to give evidence under oath, I should advise you that this hearing is a legal proceeding of the parliament and therefore has the same standing as proceedings of the respective houses. The giving of false or misleading evidence is a serious matter and may be regarded as a contempt of parliament. The evidence given today will be recorded by Hansard and attracts parliamentary privilege. I now invite you to make a brief opening statement before we proceed to discussion.

Ms Hall: I want to acknowledge that the inquiry has a broad remit. If you'll indulge me, I'm just going to focus on the opportunity to review the potential for fixed parliamentary terms.

Foundations for Tomorrow is an independent, youth driven nonprofit working to embed long-term intergenerational thinking into Australia's governance and civic life. Over the last five years, we've convened the Parliamentary Friends of Future Generations and chaired the Intergenerational Fairness Coalition, a group of 30-plus organisations advocating for long-term thinking in governance. Our mission is to equip Australian leaders to think beyond electoral cycles and to make strategic investments to build thriving communities, environment and an economy for generations to come. Right now, we can see Australia is facing really complex challenges—cost-of-living pressures, environmental concerns, housing shortages, and mental and physical health issues. Our policy and governance systems are struggling to respond effectively to long-term challenges. Short-term political incentives often outweigh generational outcomes, reform stalls, civic trust erodes, and these inequities deepen. Without structural change to embed intergenerational fairness and shared accountability, these pressures are likely to intensify and the cost of inaction will continue to grow.

If we consider how can Australia structurally reduce short-termism in politics and create the conditions for governments to plan and act with a longer term perspective, we believe that Australia should adopt four-year fixed term federal elections as a key electoral reform. By providing stability in democratic systems, fixed four-year terms reduce the strategic manoeuvring around election timing, limit the political opportunism, and allow governments to concentrate on the long-term reforms and policy implementation that the Australian people want them to.

Currently, around three out of every 10 years are effectively lost to this campaigning rather than the productive policy work. Fixed four-year terms would offer greater certainty and would support a sustained focus on the enduring outcomes, and the experience in Queensland shows us this. Queensland's move to fixed four-year terms reduced opportunities for snap elections, removed the power of the government of the day to set the election dates and enabled a longer term view in policy development and project delivery. This was a bipartisan effort and, as the former Palaszczuk government emphasised, fixed-term elections provide more time to implement policy, greater stability and a clearer focus on long-term outcomes rather than perpetual campaigning. By embedding stability into Australia's democratic structures, we can make better decisions, rebuild public trust, and ensure the choices we make today safeguard the prosperity and wellbeing of future generations.

CHAIR: Thank you so much, Emi. I'm aware of your group, Foundations for Tomorrow, and the parliamentary friendship group—a real focus on young people, their voices and their needs. We've heard evidence that young people are disengaged with politics. I mean, that's not a new phenomenon. Do you think that disengagement is increasing?

Ms Hall: I think there's a difference. I don't think young people are disengaged in the political process but I think they're not engaging in the way we have previously seen or in the cycles that parliament expects them to. I think young people today are deeply engaged in the issues that they care about, and are very vocal about what that is and what they want to do about it. But I think the missing piece is the civic engagement loop into the existing parliamentary structures that we have today and bringing them into the journey with us, or having a different approach to how we engage and consider the voices of young people.

CHAIR: So is it more the structure of our system isn't reflecting action on the issues that young people care about?

Ms Hall: Yes, I think there is a bit of distrust in all the talking, talking. Where's the action? I think there probably is a bit of a two-fold effect in that civic engagement and understanding. I guess these are long-term issues; they don't have an overnight fix. I do think there are some challenges for us as civil society to work with young people to understand the long-term effect on creating meaningful change. We need to ask: well, what are the existing avenues that can bring young people into within parliament that we can enable them to access better? But I think because that lack of trust or lack of shared accountability, where they see themselves as part of the system, is what we can work to achieve, which we could do through better shared values or through creating this

culture of what is the Australia we want to see, which is a core focus of our work into next year. And how do we bridge that gap together to create more connected communities who understand each other as well?

CHAIR: Do you think that the main cause of that distrust is that disconnection between issues young people see as important and either a lack of action or perceived lack of action at the elected level?

Ms Hall: Yes, I agree, and probably this lack of understanding of the other avenues where they can participate. It's not just attending a protest or putting your 'nup to the cup' up on your Instagram. What are the other avenues where your local MP is asking you to come and speak to them and have your voice heard, or participate in a survey or a petition or whatever the other avenues are? I think that could be a missing piece that they're not understanding is an option for them.

Senator COLBECK: I am trying to work out how to connect what you've just been talking about into the broad electoral system, because I think it's an important piece for us to consider as part of this process. So while you're looking at, say, a fixed four-year term, which is what you're considering, does that consider some of the other things that would be taken away from our democratic process in going down that path—rarely used provisions? The parliament has primacy with its numbers in relation to executive government, but taking the process to fixed terms would actually then limit the primacy of parliament over the executive. How do you see that might work with what you're proposing? Because, in my view, the primacy of parliament over the executive would be an important part in the overall creation of perception of trust and engagement if the parliament no longer has that capacity. It also is a limiting factor on the behaviour of an executive government.

Ms Hall: Thank you for the question. I think, to be honest, it's probably outside the scope of the detail of what we've considered. But I do think that potentially some of the lack of this trust and the erosion of the social contract that young Australians have with politicians is that it is very clear, in the year before a potential election, the whole year that there's potential for just this spruiking of campaign ideas. It's felt very deeply, and I think that is part of the problem of why we're seeing a wider mistrust between young people and the system of government.

Senator COLBECK: So a disconnect between the promise and the delivery or the reality?

Ms Hall: When you have a whole year where it's just words, where people don't feel the delivery is happening, that causes a lot of judgement across the whole system—you know, you just said last year that you're doing this, so how come we're now focused over here? The prolonged effect of a potential looming campaign is what is starting to affect some of that young people engagement. We'll continue to see that more as the young voting bloc grows to be the largest we've seen. I think that level of disengagement will continue to grow and widen.

Senator COLBECK: I mean, I would d agree with you that the way elected members engage with the various age groupings within our constituencies is important. Are there other factors at play, do you think, in the creation of that perception, with respect to what the expectation of young people more broadly might be?

Ms Hall: Yes, definitely. I think why young people feel these issues so deeply is because everything will affect them. There's not one topic or theme or issue that is the only thing that will be the cause. These feelings grow so strong because, for every single decision that is made, they will be the ones to take on the burden of the future impacts that have or haven't been considered, as well as how they're interconnected with other issues, and I think that's a reality. There are the feelings of that, and other mental health concerns that come off that, but that is the key difference in how young people see, perceive and interact in this system of governance, because everything is it for them. Everything could be make or break. Everything could be significantly impacting their future.

Senator COLBECK: Thank you.

CHAIR: Dr Ryan.

Dr RYAN: Thank you so much for your submission and for appearing here today. I know it's not covered in your submission, but do you have any thoughts around lowering the voting age and whether or not that might improve the engagement of young people in the democratic process in Australia?

Ms Hall: Absolutely. We absolutely must work towards that, and that would greatly change how we, in government, interact with young people. That would probably do a lot to bridge the gap in repairing that relationship between young people and the system of governance.

Dr RYAN: I agree with you, but I know that some members of this panel don't and many members of the public have concerns around extending the voting age to cover 16- and 17-year-olds. Can you describe what you think the benefits might be of doing that.

Ms Hall: We're all the same type of people; previous witnesses have said that too. I had an election on my 18th birthday, and I was so excited to receive a letter. I got a letter saying, 'Emi, you must vote,' and it's still framed in my office—so I acknowledge a bit of the privilege in that space here. There's a difference in how we treat and see young people in that they want to be heard and they want to have their viewpoint put across. We instil this in them from a very young age. You can drive from 16. Young people have a very, as I said before, unique view on how they see the world because everything impacts them; every decision that is made will directly relate to them and their future. That is the key point.

I can see the distinctions between other minimum ages, but it's the difference for a young person in what might engage them in the political process moving forward. If they were high-school age, where they were deeply engaged in a civic education program, with that aligning with the first time they could vote, I believe that would significantly improve how they then perceive the political process moving forward. It's been a structured introduction to the political process, which should be very exciting to engage with, but having that added layer around it would be very beneficial. It is very frustrating for young people today, to feel like they are shouting in a void or talking to no-one. That would go a long way to improving that relationship.

Dr RYAN: So you agree that a structured formal civics education program should, ideally, be in place for all senior school students in Australia?

Ms Hall: Absolutely—and I would be very cautious, if that wasn't in place, if we were to also lower the voting age.

Dr RYAN: Thank you very much.

CHAIR: Mr Neumann.

Mr NEUMANN: You referenced the vote that Queensland had in that plebiscite to bring Queensland in line with the other states and territories. I remember it well as a Queenslander because the Queensland chamber of commerce and the Queensland Council of Unions both supported it and campaigned together on it. The major political parties supported it. I remember being at the Ipswich Knights Football Club that night and seeing the vote get up very narrowly; I voted for it myself. I remember turning to one of my Labor colleagues there and saying, 'I wonder whether that would have got up if we had an upper house in Queensland.' If we'd had a legislative council with an eight-year term, Queenslanders may not have voted for it. I'm just wondering about the nexus here with the Senate. You strongly support fixed four-year terms in your submission and your evidence today. What do you say about the idea of eight-year Senate terms?

Ms Hall: It would be very interesting to test what that would look like. There are other states where they also have fixed terms; Queensland was the last one. There is a discourse in communities on what is responsible and what's reactive, what is best for the country in long-term thinking and the best outcome for intergenerational equity versus what will do well at the polling booth, and how we can bring Australians along on the journey. In short, the Senate should align with that and have the potential for an eight-year term. I take your point that it would take strong bipartisan support and very clear communication with the Australian public to bring them along on the journey.

Mr NEUMANN: Thank you.

CHAIR: Senator Mulholland.

Senator MULHOLLAND: The last federal election was the first time we saw gen Z and millennials outnumber baby boomer voters. We have also seen a move away from voting on election day towards prepoll and postal voting. Now that around 50 per cent of the electorate are gen Z and millennial voters, are our methods and ways of voting catering for that growth in that cohort? We haven't moved to things like online voting—we've got a little bit of telephone voting but not much online voting. Do you think there is some room to consider the method of voting, to reflect gen Z and millennial voters—whether it still suits them to vote on election day or at prepoll? I welcome your thoughts.

Ms Hall: It's clear it's not just young people who are effecting this change in voting on polling day. I definitely believe there is some work to do in how we can make it an easier process or extend prepoll. Our compulsory voting system, as others have suggested, is a responsibility. People are happy to go to a booth as long as they can easily walk through it. It's not that people don't want to do that; it's that they want to do that in an easier way. There is the potential to look at other ways of voting online in the future, but I would not link that to something that would unlock what young people—I don't think that's a barrier that is causing a lack of engagement. That would also take a really significant review into how we do that with caution and with responsibility across cyber. I wouldn't couple those two things together, but I would definitely suggest that the expansion of prepoll—the hours and the location of booths, particularly in inner-city electorates where they're quite condensed in

population—would be critical. We all know the numbers and saw election day empty, with prepoll lines being ridiculous. When we think about young people and their day-to-day movements and their behaviour, it's probably easier for them to be going on Thursday at 9 am on the way to uni as opposed to Saturday, where they're probably working somewhere else. I definitely think that would be a better focus.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Do you see fixed terms as an opportunity for the AEC to have a more rigorous approach to the way they look for prepolling booths? We've heard a lot of evidence in this committee that, with the location of prepoll booths, because we don't have fixed terms the AEC is jumping in six weeks out, in the best-case scenario, to try and lock in these locations. It is 'bottom of the barrel' in terms of what they can get. They're not close to public transport, they've got terrible carparks, they've got potholes everywhere, they've got no shade—they're just terrible; we've all got horror stories! That is a bit of a disincentive for young people and others who want to access public transport to drop into a prepolling booth on their way to work or study. Do you have any thoughts in that space?

Ms Hall: Absolutely. I can only speak from my personal experience, and I have an 18-year-old sister—we might be the nerds! She had whole groups of friends, and they were all going together because they all wanted to make sure they knew what they were doing and they wanted to make sure they felt supported. They wanted to know they could do it together. Part of their key consideration was, 'Where's the one that will have the best car park that I can go to and access?' It's definitely coupling both of those. We're in Spring Hill now, down near West End or South Bank, where there's a really high concentration of apartment. That booth was crazy, and I don't think it catered enough to that demographic.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Thank you.

Mr CALDWELL: Emi, thanks for your time today. I was sitting listening to you. This is a bit counterintuitive, but have you had a thought about whether non-compulsory voting would actually change the message to the younger voters? We always talk about how in America they spend a lot of time to sort of motivate them. It's almost like with compulsory voting—I just feel like maybe this plays out a little bit more in the younger groups—we're assuming and we take for granted that they're walking into the polling booth, so we miss all of this messaging about why they should be doing it in the first place. Maybe it's the civics education, but maybe it's the inherent part of the political world taking the vote for granted, and we're missing a preamble. So maybe it's not removing compulsory voting, but some of the flavour of not taking the vote for granted in the messaging that could help. Do you have a view on that, just as a challenge?

Ms Hall: Young people are much more engaged than we give them credit for. It sits outside of what the data tells us because they're not engaging in the structured ways that we're used to. I think the way to address that would be, as Dr Ryan said, lowering the voting age with a structured civics engagement. I think that is what that campaign would be to support a really strong entry into the system to highlight the importance. I think a lot of great work has already occurred in the civics education space; in different schools it is better or lacking.

But young people being engaged is kind of not the issue; it's just how we're funnelling them through it. I think the last election showed that young people were really highly motivated to get out. I don't think they take it well when a system is saying to them, 'Get out to vote,' so that idea of optional voting with a strong 'get out to vote' campaign is not the solution; it's how we are encouraging them to get out to vote, and the role of parents, carers and families in having these dinner table conversations about the importance and the civic responsibility that we have. I actually think it's young people leading that at the dinner table with their parents at the moment.

Mr CALDWELL: Thank you. I've got no problems with starting them young.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you, Ms Hall, for giving evidence today. I cannot say that my walls at my home or office are adorned with AEC letters, but I am super happy to know that there are young people who are really passionate about this. You've talked a lot about challenges with young people feeling engaged and feeling like they don't see themselves reflected in the system. I wanted to ask what you see as the really practical things that can be done. We've talked about civics, so I understand that. Obviously there are youth parliaments and speaking competitions and democracy talks that happen. Beyond those things, what are the really practical things that we should be looking at doing that are, of course, values based, and how do they become tangible?

Ms Hall: I think the biggest single thing that has happened, which is a major shift, was Senator Charlotte Walker. People seeing her in like the place and talking to young people through her social media in a way that truly talks to them—actually reaching them and speaking their language—has been the biggest shift. You can actually look up and see young people represented and think: 'I also am a part of that. I can see myself in that system, being able to talk and communicate.'

I like Youth Parliament and those speaking competitions, of course. However, I do think they attract a certain type of young person who was already likely to be deeply engaged. It's the same for the membership of political parties: they were already going to find their way there whatever happened. What it is, though, is that connection to other groups. How do we go beyond the Youth Parliament? How do we get each of them, each of the young MPs or whatever they're called? Where are their networks and friendship groups, and how do we also bring them into the community? It's broadening up those conversations and also creating structured ways for young people to have a voice and a place at the table—and not just a token young person. It's how we make them feel that they're truly included in the process, that their voice will be heard and that their perspective will be embedded into the decision-making.

I think the challenge at the moment is that they feel like there may be opportunities for them to say something or to be somewhere, but they're one person who was just there and was likely told what to say or was able to say it because it aligned with someone else's view or the views of the adults at the table. It's about creating more opportunities to have multiple young people in multiple rooms, and I think that's the difference. It shows genuine engagement, rather than a tokenistic view. Young people are very attuned to bullshit—sorry, if we're not allowed to swear—so they want to see the outcome. They will follow up and look back at what you've said and if you've done it. They will look back at what they've said to you and if you've even considered that in your decision-making.

Ms CAMPBELL: More Charlotte Walkers.

CHAIR: Following on from that question, I know a lot of people in their 30s, 40s and 50s who are very disengaged from politics. So is there anything specific or different that we should be focused on to engage young people, or is it just the same problem across multiple generations? What's different about young people when it comes to disengagement and getting them engaged again?

Ms Hall: I think it comes back to that start. Because every single issue affects young people, that's when they have the biggest momentum to engage. If we focus on early civic engagement, that will follow through. I have a two-year-old. As soon as she was born, everything changed—how I perceive things. So I think for that voting block of 30s, 40s and 50s you will find specific issues that they care deeply about that will cause them to really want to engage in certain policy areas or topics. It's just not felt across the whole spectrum of government; it's just a singular issue. There will be a flow-on effect: the more people who are engaged earlier on and feel that their voices are heard and start to build that trust in government and civic awareness—that will carry through and evolve differently. But that's also the easiest starting point, because everything is a concern. Everything is an issue. We have heard it and felt it deeply—the young people today care about all these issues.

CHAIR: Thank you for your attendance here today. We really appreciate it. If you've been asked to provide any additional information, please forward it to the secretariat by Friday 9 January. And you may get some written questions on notice sent by the secretariat. You will be sent a copy of the transcript of your evidence and will have an opportunity to request corrections of any transcription errors. Thanks for your time today.

BARTLETT, Mr Andrew, Private capacity

[11:44]

CHAIR: Welcome. Although the committee does not require you to give evidence under oath, I should advise you that this hearing is a legal proceeding of the parliament and therefore has the same standing as proceedings of the respective houses. The giving of false or misleading evidence is a serious matter and may be regarded as a contempt of parliament. The evidence given today will be recorded by Hansard and attracts parliamentary privilege. I now invite you to make a brief opening statement before we proceed to discussion.

Mr Bartlett: Thank you for the opportunity, for the invitation to appear today and for the time you're taking on this inquiry. You can see in my submission that the last election was the first one that I actually wasn't intensely involved with since 1990. There were however many elections from 1990 to 2022, along with state and local ones. I've had a fair bit of involvement in electoral processes in many, many different capacities. I've been a member of your esteemed committee myself at times and all of those things, so I feel that I've got that experience.

I may as well let you know my impressions, given the issues before you, in case you're interested. My overarching one, having read some of the transcripts of other things and heard some of the comments even today—overall, it's about our electoral system and our electoral process. I'm a bit of an electoral systems nerd, not surprisingly. The Australian Electoral Commission is just world class, and anything you can do to protect it and improve it even further, particularly at this time, when there are probably some wild and crazy times ahead locally and globally in the world of politics—if people lose faith in the voting system itself, I think you all know that's a pretty bad thing. Anything to strengthen even further its independence and its funding—if I could leave no other message, I'd leave that with you.

In regard to some of the issues around activities at polling booths and voting places et cetera, I think there's a good case to be made for trying to regulate. Humans are going to be humans, and people find ways to work around things, but I still think you can put in place some things to try and dial the intensity back a bit around polling places, which would be good for the voter, most importantly, and would actually help with that broader idea of trying to engage people in the voting process and the political process to make it a more pleasant experience for everyone, all of whom are volunteers. We're wanting to encourage people to engage and connect and find that a good experience.

In terms of the specific issue of the number of seats in the House of Reps et cetera, I think there's an extremely strong case for increasing the number of seats in the House of Reps. I haven't heard any case at all for why there should be an increase in the size of the Senate beyond the fact that there would just have to be because the nexus is in the Constitution. The nexus is nonsense. Holding a referendum to get rid of the nexus is an extremely good idea. I presume I don't need to make the case to you as to why I'm not anti-Senate, but the nexus is just ridiculous. But we should have more people in the House of Reps for reasons I can expand on if you're interested. There may be a good case for why we need more senators—and maybe the reason people haven't made the case for why we need more senators is because they don't need to, because it'll just happen automatically—but I genuinely can't see it. I can see some reasons for the opposite, to be honest. That's my opening bit for you.

CHAIR: Thank you, Mr Bartlett. I've got a few questions about the reasons for increasing the seats in the House of Reps. I think the case for the Senate is the Constitution. I think time has proven it's quite difficult to change that, but I take your points. A few people have recommended removing the nexus. But, on increasing the parliament's size as a whole, is population enough of a reason for this to be considered by government?

Mr Bartlett: It's a good case, in part, but I think there's something on top of that, and this is genuinely based on my experience. More resourcing for staffing and all those other things that people can do as a representative, whether it's in the House of Reps, a state parliament or local council, to support people is important, but a key part of people maintaining some degree of faith in how the voting system is meant to work—we vote for people and they represent us—is feeling like they can connect with you. Eventually, if the size of your electorate gets too large, I think it becomes extremely difficult for people. They feel, 'I can't connect with this person', 'My vote doesn't matter,' and all those things.

I haven't been in the House of Representatives, despite a few efforts, but there's that psychological aspect, even on top of the workload of the MP. You can have as many staff as you like, but I'm sure you could tell me better than I can tell you that you are the people's representative and they need to be able to meet you. You can't replace yourself. AI might replace everything else, but it probably can't replace that. They need to be able to meet you. I think, once you get beyond a certain size, that dissipates. If you add that to all the other concerns people have about validity and whether the whole thing is just a farce anyway, I think it's actually pretty important. I also think

it will require politicians, elected representatives, to be more connected to their community, because the smaller your electorate is the more you need to earn each of those votes directly.

CHAIR: I want to flesh out that connection for the purposes of evidence. You mentioned meeting. There's only a small subset of an electorate that ever have their requirement to meet their MP met. How else would you see connections with communities be improved with greater representation, and what does that mean to your average voter?

Mr Bartlett: Well, the whole idea of an electorate is about place and connection. I feel that the more people can feel part of a community, and the more they feel their representative is part of that community, the more that will give them confidence in this whole voting thing. It's not just about numbers for political parties and all of that stuff; it's about people, and it needs to be about people. The more it gets removed from people—I don't want to get into a wider political commentary, but I think that's part of why some of the things that are changing in electoral political contexts around the world are happening the way they're happening. People feel like this is just another world out there that they're not actually connected to. There are good reasons why they might think that, but this is one antidote. It's not going to fix everything. I'm not trying to pretend this is the one thing that will stop everything else falling apart, but you may as well do what you can, so you should do it.

CHAIR: Thank you. Deputy Chair.

Senator COLBECK: I just want to go back to your point around maintaining the integrity of the AEC. I would agree with you 100 per cent on that. They are a trusted organisation, and one thing we must do is work to maintain and enhance that trust. In the context of managing things around polling booths outside of the direct zone of the AEC, you say that it should not be their job to manage that. Who would you see doing that, and what would you see as the best process to manage that?

Mr Bartlett: Outside of the polling booth precinct?

Senator COLBECK: Outside the six metres. The AEC say they have no control outside the six metres. Local government might have some regulations with respect to signage. At state level, there are various types of regulatory process or legislation around how many signs you can have. Here in Queensland it's one thing. In Tasmania it's 100 metres and nobody on a polling booth and no how-to-vote cards.

Mr Bartlett: It sounds lovely. I should move to Tasmania!

Senator COLBECK: But somebody has to manage the area that's outside the jurisdiction of the AEC. Who is best placed to manage that? The political parties probably have a role to play, but who is best placed to manage that. If it's not the AEC—and I'm agreeing with you that it shouldn't be—how do you best manage that?

Mr Bartlett: I don't want to overthink it. Part of setting regulations and changing things is changing culture and expectations as well. We don't want to send in the Army, or whatever, to police it—bring out their measuring tapes and measure the size of corflutes and all that stuff.

Senator COLBECK: No—party members will bring those anyway.

Mr Bartlett: Once it's outside of the jurisdiction of the AEC and Australian electoral law, then it's sort of not your job anyway, really. It's more about guidance and stuff like that. In fact, it's not your job. Once it's outside the jurisdiction of the Electoral Act, it is up to councils and state governments, or whoever it is, which works differently everywhere. I think it's good for people to have signage and all that sort of stuff around the suburbs and all those sorts of things. Personally—just throwing it forward—I like the idea, as I think I put in my submission, of being required to register electoral material with the AEC in advance, whether it's a how-to-vote card or whether it's other stuff, like corflutes. Any electoral material anywhere still comes under the jurisdiction of electoral law, wherever it is, and I do think it's important to have that as strongly regulated as possible. Again, making my point about funding, it's all very easy to say the AEC should cover every piece of material and every leaflet everywhere, but that costs money and time. I think that's the key part of what needs to be done, for you folks.

Senator COLBECK: In respect of postal voting, you made a point about the decline in the reliability of the postal system. Do you have any suggestions as to how we might manage that? I agree with you that the time taken for deliveries these days has blown out because of the logistics of letters, but are there any measures that you can think of that we should take to ensure the integrity of that part of the system?

Mr Bartlett: It's a genuine problem. I think the broad principle is: give everybody an opportunity to vote and give them all means to make that as easy as possible. For people to be able to apply for postal votes, getting the ballot paper to them as early as possible is about the best we can do. But I am aware of the time it takes. I got a

letter in the mail just yesterday. I moved two blocks down the road in the inner city and it took a month for a letter to get to my mailbox. And that was from Australia Post itself.

Senator COLBECK: That's a great advertisement!

Mr Bartlett: It's a wicked problem. I don't really know what you do about that, but I also want to make very clear that I do not support online voting at all.

Senator COLBECK: Is there a role, perhaps, for the government to ensure resourcing for Australia Post during an electoral period to make sure that the timeframe is within certain parameters?

Mr Bartlett: I wouldn't be against that.

Senator COLBECK: It could be a service guarantee type situation that might occur.

Mr Bartlett: Yes. I'm not quite sure how you'd do it, but I certainly wouldn't be protesting if you wanted to suggest a mechanism for doing that.

Senator COLBECK: What about the period of prepoll voting versus election day voting? Do you have a perspective on that?

Mr Bartlett: I can't remember what I ended up putting in my submission, because I drafted it a few times and I didn't get around to re-reading it before I appeared today—which is no disrespect to you; I was just doing other things. But I think two weeks is enough, and probably one and a bit weeks. The key principle is that people must have the opportunity to vote and it must be made as easy as possible. But I do have a concern about people voting—I know this contradicts what I've just said about postal voting, but the world is full of paradoxes—before all the policies are announced. That just doesn't sit very comfortably with me. I usually know how I'm going to vote, so I can vote early. But I feel like a week or so is enough, frankly, for prepolls.

Also, there is the resource cost to the AEC, I might say. Finding places, keeping those places open and staffing those for however long it takes is a genuine issue for them. They'll tell you; they know better than I do. That's a genuine component as well.

Senator COLBECK: Thank you.

CHAIR: Senator Mulholland, do you have any questions for Mr Bartlett?

Senator MULHOLLAND: I do, thank you. Welcome back! Thank you for joining us. Two things in your submission jumped out at me. The first was around removing the impediments to people voting early and removing the requirement for a voter to give reasons. A number of states have removed that from their state electoral acts. I wanted to offer you an opportunity to talk to that.

Mr Bartlett: I just think it's silly. Why? Either you can vote or you can't. Why do you have to give a reason—

Senator MULHOLLAND: Why you're entitled to vote early.

Mr Bartlett: why you're voting early—like because you can't do it on polling day. I'm sorry, but we all know that people vote early because it's easier to vote early. Why have to lie? It's one less question that the AEC staff have to ask. It just seems stupid to me.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Sure—a bit of a no-brainer, that one. The other one was around disinformation in election material and looking at a take-down power for the AEC around social media and online material and then also, potentially, a geoblocking power. We put these questions to the AEC quite early on in this committee inquiry, and they put a fairly strong view to us that they didn't believe they were the arbiters of truth or mistruth. They felt that that sat with the voter, and they couldn't really give us a view about, if not them, what other government body could do it. They felt it sat clearly with the voter to decide what was true or not true and to take action on it. Can you talk me through why you think there's a need for a take-down power for material, particularly in social media and online, and then what the geoblocking power would do and how that would operate.

Mr Bartlett: I'm trying to keep things broad rather than get into the micro of how it might work. You're the legislators; if you accept the principle, you can figure out how to do it. I know you all know about the need for truth in advertising and truth in political advertising. I very much understand—and I know the AEC has said for a very long time that they don't want that. It was actually passed into law. I feel duty bound to put it on the record that the Democrats passed it into law back in 1983 or something—because probably no-one will ever say it again on the record—and then it got removed again. There's a version of it in South Australia, and I think that version works fine. To those that advocate truth in political advertising: (a) be careful what you wish for and (b) it wouldn't work. It would be people just running around, pointing at each other and saying, 'That's a lie,' et cetera.

But I'm talking specifically about electoral disinformation about how the voting system works and that sort of thing—that just voting 1 is a valid vote and those sorts of things; I think it's already against the law to do that—particularly in the context of the real potential for online stuff that pushes the sort of thing that says you can just vote 1 and it will be a valid vote or that's completely misinforming people about how they can actually vote appearing from anywhere in the world. That does already happen, and it can happen more. There are existing laws that enable take-downs of various things and of other types of material. Should that sit with the AEC in this context? It would be pretty narrow. I'm not talking about people saying this party's bad or this party's good or whatever. It's about the sort of stuff that would ruin people's votes.

The AEC already does this a bit, and they do it quite well, I think—mostly with their Twitter accounts and that sort of stuff. They're just trying to correct misinformation and disinformation already online. So that's the sort of thing I'm trying to get at, not the broader truth-in-advertising stuff—'They said something nasty about me, and I want that taken down.' I'm talking about that much more specific misleading of people about how the electoral system works.

Senator MULHOLLAND: I'm not going to ask you to explain how that geoblocking power would work. You didn't come here in the capacity of a computer whiz; I appreciate that. But would you see that as being an opportunity to look at a reserve power for an appropriate authority should there be international interference—international actors or material from outside of Australia—being pushed into, say, a particular culturally and linguistically diverse community, telling them, 'It's okay to vote 1. You just have to vote 1'? Is that what you would see this geoblocking power being?

Mr Bartlett: Yes. It's not dissimilar to what the AEC can already do with analogue bits of paper and stuff. People put out stuff. They can withdraw it. They've done that; they did it at the last election. But it happens online. They should have a power to be able to deal with it when it happens online, and geoblocking is a power that already exists in various other laws. I know why the AEC doesn't want to have more things to do, so give them more resources or have them have a little section that focuses on that. They already focus a lot on online. They do good stuff online. All I'm suggesting is that, when it's an open-and-shut case, they have a clearly defined authority, as they already have with bits of paper, either to block it or to request a take-down or whatever.

There's a lot of legislative stuff happening on a much wider scale on social media right now, as you all know, and it's never going to be perfect. I'm not saying there has to be a perfect solution, but just because you can't fix something perfectly doesn't mean you don't at least try to do something.

Senator MULHOLLAND: I want to give a shout-out to the AEC's social media team. I think they did a really good job with their myth busting at the last election.

CHAIR: They did a great job there.

Senator MULHOLLAND: That's all I had. Thank you, Mr Bartlett.

CHAIR: Dr Ryan.

Dr RYAN: Thank you so much for coming in today. I'm interested in your thoughts regarding the involvement of third parties at prepoll and at polling sites. In 2025, in some electorates, we experienced a number of quite hostile third parties presenting to prepoll and polling sites, and, in some cases, they presented information which was actively misleading or non-factual, shall we say. You said the AEC could monitor that sort of information. Is it your proposition that the AEC would see everything that was likely to be presented at those sites and okay it in advance? We're not just talking about A-frames; we're talking about mobile vans and the like. It's probably only a matter of time until we have planes flying overhead trailing signs and things like that. How do we stop this? Often it's been reported to us that, when people are authorising these signs, either the authorisations were inaccurate or wrong or they were third-party players that are unknown to people within their community.

Mr Bartlett: The first thing to say is that you can't stop humans being human. But, like the previous question, there are still some things you can try and do to at least mitigate it and shift the culture a bit, not just the behaviour of the individual people but the culture of people's understanding that any of that sort of stuff is just garbage to start with. You can do some of that with laws, and there are other ways to do it. I wanted to make that point for starters. Trying to regulate what people put on their cars driving around the city is getting a bit more challenging, but, on polling booths themselves, I think it's about, again, properly resourcing the AEC. There are already some states—I'm fairly sure Queensland still does it—where you have to pre-register your how-to-vote cards or something like that.

It would make it easy for the AEC if they were sufficiently resourced on a polling booth if you've got to pre-register your material. So unless it's pre-registered and looked at in advance of polling day, you can't hand it out. It doesn't matter what's on it. That would make it easier for the AEC and the polling-booth people on the day: 'We

don't have that. Sorry, you can't hand it out.' It would also mean that if there's anything on it that's obviously outrageous then they could not approve it in advance. It's not going to fix everything, but it'd just be a little bit of a something. I don't know what to do about the trucks driving around; I'm sorry. I don't know what to do about that or with planes and all of those things. People still get messages on their mobile phones while they're walking in to vote or whatever.

Dr RYAN: Do you think that we should outline the use of carriage services in respect to voting messages? Do you have an issue with the use of mobile phones and messaging—for example, the use of carriage services—for that sort of messaging? Given you can't have political advertising and that there's theoretically a black-out period, do you think we should extend that to mobile phones?

Mr Bartlett: I think it'd be great if you could find a way to do it. We're supposed to have a no-call list. I get five spam calls a day on my phone even though I'm on every no-call list on the planet. I don't know how you actually make it work, but, if you can find a way to make it work, that'd be great. Go for it.

CHAIR: Mr Neumann?

Mr NEUMANN: Thank you, Mr Bartlett. Welcome back to JSCEM. You say on the bottom of page seven:

The issue of threatening and aggressive behaviour at polling booths is a very real issue.

You said that this is the first election you haven't been actively involved in at a federal, state or council level since 1990. It's a very real issue. What's the basis for you saying that?

Mr Bartlett: That's because I've seen it before 2025. I'm not saying it's a chronic problem in every single electorate or at every single booth, but I think it's a thing, and, again, you can't stop people being people just by changing the electoral act, but I think there are things you can do to help try and dial it back. Some of it's the culture of staking out the booths the night before, wrapping booths in five miles of plastic and all those sorts of things. Anything that reduces that idea that the polling booth is a battle ground instead of a welcoming place for people to come and do their voting thing would help dial that back.

Mr NEUMANN: In the previous paragraph to that, you say:

The Australian Electoral Commission, especially their employees at polling places but also their general staff, should never be expected to take on a quasi-policing role.

Yet the legislation really gives them that role within the six-metre rule. I'm interested in that contradiction. You said the world's full of ironies and paradoxes. It's true. But you talk about the fact that they shouldn't expect 'aggressive behaviour and obstructive conduct without sufficient authority or legal protections'. Do you think they've got sufficient authority or legal protections?

Mr Bartlett: Obviously that's a question better directed to them. I think one of the things that are always going to be challenges for the AEC is that, obviously, they've got to hire an enormous number of staff for a short period of time across an enormous number of polling booths. By virtue of my experience, and I'm sure you've all seen it too—the variation in how different polling booth officers interpret things can be frustrating for folks who are political candidates, for parties and contestants and independents and all of those, when you go from one booth to the next, even whether you can stand in the shade or not. I think that's just part of the things you've got to accept. As you all know, it's a massive operation. Even finding all the suitable booths would be one good reason, at least, to have fixed terms, so they could properly plan for the actual polling day and so people could perhaps be, in advance, clearer about some of those really basic things—where the six-metre line even is and all that sort of stuff.

But I'm not going to tell the AEC how they should do their job. As I say, I think they're fantastic. Anything that could make it easier for them to be able to seem like they're being less subjective and that it's clear cut, without requiring them—I think it's better to ask them that question.

Mr NEUMANN: Thank you.

CHAIR: Mr Caldwell?

Mr CALDWELL: I'm fine, thanks, but thank you, Andrew, for your time.

CHAIR: Mr Burnell.

Mr BURNELL: Thank you, Mr Bartlett. I want to go back to some comments around Australia Post and the provision of postal voting. I want to get your thoughts on whether or not you see a world where, potentially, we lose the delivery of postal votes by Australia Post as part of their carriage service and, if so, what potential options there would be to fill the void that would be created.

Mr Bartlett: As we've already discussed, the slowness of the post is a real problem—and just how rare mail is becoming—so I can certainly see a future where that's very likely. This isn't an ideological view—pro-privatisation or antiprivatisation per se—but I think the one thing you've really got to do everything you can to protect is people's confidence that the voting system itself isn't rigged. If you were to start contracting out the delivery of postal votes and stuff to any private provider, I can see how that would work in terms of the narrative and what people would create around it. I am antiprivatisation, but that's not the point; the point is the confidence in the voting process.

I don't quite know what the answer is to that, particularly given that I think voting online is even more of a problem (a) logistically and (b) in relation to, again, the narratives of what people would say about that. But it needs to be maintained, so I think it'd need to be a—I was going to say: 'Give it to the AEC. Have the AEC set up their own postal service or something.' I'm sure they would be fiercely resistant to having extra jobs, but I'm not quite sure. Anyway, it's a genuine thing that people need to be conscious of.

Obviously, there are more and more people that don't vote on the election day; there are more and more people that are voting earlier. Whether the trends on postal voting will stay what they are—they might. I think they probably will, personally, particularly if polling booths stay hostile places. I don't particularly want to go to a polling booth. Maybe that's just PTSD or something.

But, also, hey, it's easy. You want to make it easy for people to vote, but you've got to retain the confidence in the electoral system. You've also got to be confident your vote is actually going to get there in time. The AEC may have done some work on how many votes come in past the closing date and how long the votes have taken to get there. I don't know. I haven't seen any commentary on that. I might be overdramatising it all, but it just concerns me.

Mr BURNELL: Thank you.

CHAIR: Thanks, Mr Burnell. Ms Campbell?

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you for giving evidence today. In relation to your point about postage, we've had reports in this committee in the past about difficulty voting, particularly in remote Queensland—areas where the idea of getting postage in and out in the period is near impossible—and, in some of those cases, due to weather, people not being able to actually get out to do a vote on the day. In the context of your point around postage, what are the options that you think are most viable for people in remote areas?

Mr Bartlett: Having lived my entire life in the inner city of Brisbane, I'm not sure I'm best placed to speak about what things are like in the remote areas of Queensland, although I have been to many of them. But, seeing as you've asked, the expense of hand delivery or whatever is obviously absurd. You've got to accept that nothing's perfect. In the integrity of the system, in fact, everybody's got a chance and occasionally a few things go wrong. If a result in a particular electorate is 10 votes one way or the other, and people—

Ms CAMPBELL: But I firmly believe that everyone should have the opportunity to vote, and apparently—

Mr Bartlett: Of course they should. I'm just saying that we've got to try our best to ensure that that core principle that you've mentioned happens and also accept that sometimes we will fail, as long as it doesn't become deliberate. But that's the thing: when you accept that principle, you've got to invest in it. You've got to spend the money to ensure that the ballot can be delivered to people and that people's ballots can get back in and be counted. And that costs money.

Ms CAMPBELL: Obviously, I very firmly believe that everyone should have the opportunity to vote. In your submission, you talked about the fact that we should have more democracy, and that was the reason that you don't support four-year terms. How do you reconcile that with your position that we should also have less opportunity to vote in prepolls by truncating that into, I think you said, about a week and, maybe, a little bit?

Mr Bartlett: I just think that's enough for people—unless there've been studies showing that people haven't had the opportunity to vote because the prepolls weren't open long enough. It's a lot of investment, it's a lot of time, it's a lot of money, it's a lot of—

Ms CAMPBELL: Should that be the standard: how much investment and time it takes to ensure that we have full enfranchisement?

Mr Bartlett: I'm not sure what you're saying, sorry.

Ms CAMPBELL: You've just said it takes a lot of money and a lot of time, and you suggest that that, maybe, is something that should impact whether or not we make sure everyone can have a vote.

Mr Bartlett: I don't think there's any evidence that says that people have been denied the ability to vote because prepolls aren't long enough. I mean, you can leave them open longer. It was just my view that, while a lot

of people are already exercising that opportunity, which I'm fine with, I do have a concern, as I said earlier on, that, if they're open too long, you have people voting before half the policies have been released—literally before people are doing their campaign launches and all that sort of stuff.

Ms CAMPBELL: My point was just that the idea of having more democracy, as you've said by saying that you don't support four-year terms, is incongruent with the idea of also shortening the opportunity to vote at each election.

Mr Bartlett: Well, by virtue of three-year terms rather than four-year terms, people get more opportunity to vote, so I'm all in favour of people voting. But, in my view, they're two separate issues. One is how often there are elections and the other is how those elections work. I'd prefer three-year terms over four-year terms. My much stronger view is we should get rid of the nexus, but I have a much stronger view about a lot of other things. It doesn't actually exercise my mind that much, but I think it's on principle. The idea that having fewer elections somehow helps democracy work better doesn't make sense to me. As to how those elections work, whether they're three-year terms, four-year terms, two-year terms or five-year terms, I think that that's a separate issue.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you.

CHAIR: Thank you, Mr Bartlett, for your time today. If you've been asked to provide any additional information, would you please forward it to the secretariat by 9 January 2026. You'll be sent a copy of the transcript of your evidence, and we'll have an opportunity to request corrections to any errors.

ORR, Professor Graeme, Private capacity

[12:25]

CHAIR: I now call Professor Graeme Orr. Although the committee does not require you to give evidence under oath, I should advise you that this hearing is a legal proceeding of the parliament and therefore has the same standing as proceedings of the respective houses. The giving of false or misleading evidence is a serious matter and may be regarded as a contempt of parliament. The evidence given today will be recorded by Hansard and attracts parliamentary privilege. I now invite you to make a brief opening statement before we proceed to discussion.

Prof. Orr: Thank you, Chair, and thank you to the committee for the invitation. I haven't made a submission. Normally, when locals come up to this part of the town, it's to visit medical specialists, so I think this will be a relatively enjoyable experience. I've only got a couple of comments, and the comments arise from the super-duper bill that was passed late last year. I also have one comment that is more about a matter of principle.

In relation to the giant bill from late last year, as we know, most of it doesn't commence until mid next year—most of the campaign finance reforms. It'll obviously be very important for this committee to have a very thorough review. We may not get a hotly contested by-election before then, but one thing will cut in before then, and that's the increased disclosure requirements. Obviously, it's very important that the electoral commission is well resourced. It's not just capacity, people and resources; I think it's also partly about an enforcement mentality, which is very important.

I'm really looking forward to the end, hopefully, of $100,000-plus donations to the major business forums of the major parties—which the electoral commission said, in the face of the purpose and the letter of the law, were not necessarily disclosable—or, at least, they'll be channelled and disclosed in other ways.

One caveat about the bill wasn't well debated in a public sense, because it was such a complex piece of legislation negotiated between the parties. The bill smuggled through a provision—which I wonder if many members of your parties are aware of—that put the final nail in the coffin of the possibility of members' going to the courts to enforce party rules. I think that was a significant reform, helping undo 30 years of common law on that point, and there wasn't any debate about that.

The point of principle—the lowering, maybe, of the voting age has been raised a couple of times. As someone who's taught law students for too long, I don't claim to have any great empirical understanding of the wider perspective of younger people, other than my own children. There's a great paper from some years ago by Dr Joanne Lau of the ANU, a philosopher, pointing out that, since the age of criminal responsibility is 17—and I'm sitting here in a state where, like in most states, there are lots of debates about criminal responsibility—if you're going to be able to be thrown in an adult jail at 17, you probably should be able to vote at 17.

The other point, finally, is that very few people get to vote at 18. I noticed one of the earlier submitters said she was very happy that she turned 18 just in time for the election, but that's pretty rare. Some people will turn 21 before they get to vote. So, really, on average, a young person does not get to vote at a Commonwealth election until they're 19½.

CHAIR: That's an interesting perspective, Professor. Thanks for your submission today and for coming to give evidence. You mentioned you're in support of donation caps and the increased transparency of donation disclosure. Do you support the limits on expenditure per electorate? I'd be interested in your thoughts on the $800,000-per-electorate expenditure caps.

Prof. Orr: Yes, in principle, as I've written for many years, the act, in terms of its values, is one that is comprehensive, and the devil will be in the detail. There's an extraordinary amount of complexity in the legislation, and my concern, most deeply, is for new players and startups and smaller third parties and community groups and so on. To be frank, I've spent 30 years staring at this kind of legislation and I struggled to explain to my students—let alone in things I've written for the law societies—the complexity of this legislation. So that would be one thing to keep in mind.

CHAIR: As to this specific legislation, or do you mean just electoral legislation in general?

Prof. Orr: No, particularly in relation to the FAD, capped funding and disclosure, and campaign finance stuff. Some of it is because there's an assumption that there's a cat-and-mouse game going on. That then raises other questions about whether the Electoral Commission, as a singular body, is the right institution to enforce and educate on these kinds of laws. I can only point to the United Kingdom and the US, where things are certainly imperfect but they do have distinct bodies there, dealing with the kind of accounting and policing aspects of

campaign political party finance laws, separate to the kind of body that just wants to deliver a big happy logistical event, and, in a sense, please everyone, democratically.

In terms of expenditure limits, I've been a longstanding proponent of them—partly because expenditure has traditionally been public, and hence, in theory, is more enforceable. But of course we are moving into times where a lot of expenditure occurs in less public ways, and we're moving away from broadcasting, for instance, and into the social media realm and so on.

To some extent, expenditure is not as important as it was, given that a lot of campaigning now goes on all through the term—you don't fatten the pig on market day—and you're doing a lot of stuff that is designed to go viral, for example. But of course all money helps, and we should have had expenditure limits back when Mr Palmer was running, if only to save his company $100 million!

CHAIR: Drawing on that, what do you think of the expenditure limits? You said you agree with the intent. What value are they trying to entrench in our political system? Why do you think they are a big feature of these laws that have recently passed?

Prof. Orr: They are a feature around the world because the idea—well, the hope is that political debates are somehow about your values and your policies, if not your charisma and so on. It isn't just something for, for example, most obviously, a billionaire to come along and to capture a lot of attention, which then the media doubles and triples, and that can distort the agenda. I am not saying Mr Palmer had that kind of impact, but he certainly did on what you might call the new right side of politics, where he was competing with four or five other parties and he stole a march on them. But expenditure limits are also significant. They can't be simple. There can't be a single limit, obviously, because we have Senate races and we have marginal seat races, so—

CHAIR: And whole-of-country contests as well—leadership contests.

Prof. Orr: Yes.

CHAIR: Deputy Chair.

Senator COLBECK: I have a couple of questions. On the discussion around third-party entities, do you see any danger in the legislation, as someone who has spent too much time staring at it, as to it driving more resources towards third-party entities and their involvement in the political system?

Prof. Orr: We have certainly seen some of that in Australia. We are not the United States, though. My concerns would be if we were to get more astroturfing and behind-the-scenes coordination with groups that don't really have a social base. That would be problematic. We've also seen the rise of third parties partly because of most parties losing some of not just their membership base but their social connections as well. It's not necessarily a bad thing, as long as it's organic. As to the driving of it, as I said, I think the complexity of the legislation might make it difficult for some groups that might want to get involved—if they fear the intricacies of the legislation and its enforcement against them. I think it's important that the Electoral Commission and any other enforcement authorities focus on the main game and don't pick on the little guys.

Senator COLBECK: Yes, but those with large resources will have a larger capacity and a stronger capacity to understand and manage those intricacies of the legislation, would they not?

Prof. Orr: Yes, that's one of the problems with regulation. If you make things more complex and intricate for the best of purposes or even just to attend to a cat-and-mouse game, yes, it does create a situation where, unless there's some kind of ombudsman or mechanism where people can go for assistance and so on, then those who are better advised will find leeway if not loopholes.

Senator COLBECK: I agree with your point 'don't fatten the pig on market day'. There are plenty of very sage political operators that have run that mantra over a long time. But I found very interesting your point about the continuous campaign being designed more around moments to go viral—because does it not then drive people towards campaign mechanisms and messages that are designed in that light and, therefore, impact on the reality of the message? It's more to the extremes, I suppose you might say. You mentioned Mr Palmer; he certainly was in that category with some of the stuff that he was putting out during the campaign over a period of time, to be frank. But, even within some of the other political parties, some of the things that are being said now tend to be more extreme so that they do attract attention and, as you say, go viral, and they therefore have an impact on the political process and discourse.

Prof. Orr: Yes. We're living in the so-called age of the attention economy. Mr Palmer—I've been a Queenslander for a long time; I've watched him. He was Mr Trump before Mr Trump. He was doing things like twerking in public and going on radio stations and so on to get this unpaid-for but earned attention. Now, later on, he's moved to a MAGA mode, where he's actually spending a lot of money to do that. So I don't really think that

bringing in expenditure caps is going to cause or terribly inflame a situation. And there are other reasons. The culture, sadly, might be moving to controversialism and look-at-me-ism and so on. There's a lot of research around that. People wanting to reach out to younger people are using social media in ways—it's going to happen anyway, regardless of what this current bill does, so I wouldn't be concerned that you're fanning the flames. But that kind of culture is very hard to regulate, and you've talked about some of the most extremes of it today.

Senator COLBECK: Thanks.

CHAIR: Dr Ryan?

Dr RYAN: Professor Orr, is it your position that the campaign donation reforms that were legislated at the end of last year would act to actively disadvantage members of smaller parties and Independents, as opposed to members of the large parties, at Australian federal elections?

Prof. Orr: I think, on the whole, it's beneficial for smaller parties and smaller actors to have limits, even if those limits are imperfectly enforced, and certainly in relation to donations, because there is a wealth of research to show that donations follow incumbency or an opposition that's about to get into government. In relation to the position of Independents, I do think there is some potential for a constitutional challenge here. I think one thing that should have been looked at is increasing the amount of funding for Independents, which is the South Australian model traditionally, to provide some counterbalance. That is more in relation to economies of scale, and there are Independents and there are Independents.

CHAIR: Please explain further!

Dr RYAN: Could you explain that?

Prof. Orr: There are Independents who have very high profiles, who may have access to significant resources and who may be able to sometimes work together. There are Independents who are running purely on their own, with not a lot of background. I'm not just referring to the so-called teals; I'm also referring to those Independents who might come through being, say, an already well-established mayor of a city, who have different resources and advantages than other kinds of Independents.

The law, though, tends to want to regulate things. I guess one size fits all. I think that is a problem in our way of thinking about the law. We think the rule of law means you have to regulate big players and small players in exactly the same way. Well, we don't always do that. The four per cent threshold creates a distinction that's justifiable, I think. As I said, in the South Australian kind of public funding model you give more for the first percentage of votes received, or you can give more to Independents and so on, to counteract some of the problems you have when you're fighting well-established parties.

I think one thing that came out of the last election was, really, a slow systemic question. Our election result this year was very similar to that in the United Kingdom if you think about the disproportionality of it, and we're getting this slow decline of the vote share of major parties without the kinds of party realignment we're seeing in other countries. That may partly be because things like public funding, but particularly compulsory voting, have tamped things down in Australia, and we've got more stability because of that. But I don't see people here on this committee, or generally, agitating for, say, MMP and those kinds of changes, which I think would be more philosophically and principally consistent with the kinds of slow, creeping changes we're seeing in the party system in this country.

Dr RYAN: I think we're going to hear about that this afternoon, actually. We have someone who wants to talk to us about that. Would you agree that the changes to the electoral donation rules that were legislated at the end of last year significantly benefit people who do have incumbency, whether they're Independents, small-party representatives or party representatives, as opposed to new challengers who aren't allied to a party?

Prof. Orr: No, I don't, because the bigger picture is that unrestrained access to donations and expenditure, which we're trying to move away from, hugely benefits those who have established positions, power, authority, access to the media, et cetera.

Dr RYAN: How about if we talk about the fact that the parties have access to funding from entities that are, in some instances, very well funded and have very deep pockets. I'm talking about the Liberal Party; the Labor Party, with its relationship with the unions; and the Greens nominated entity. Independents don't have access to third-party funding or funding from nominated entities and might be disadvantaged by that.

Prof. Orr: There's a lot of cachet with being an Independent. We know that from CCC inquiries in the Gold Coast and so on. People want the label 'Independent'. If that means you aren't going to be coordinating with other groups, then that's part of being truly independent, I guess. The idea that we would—I won't say it would be unconstitutional, but it would be very odd to try and pull apart, for instance, the Labor Party's traditional structure.

In this type of legislation, there are limits on the amount of money that can be gifted into, at least, campaign expenditure accounts by things like trade unions, which means that maybe—this is possibly Mr Colbeck's point, in a way—some of the money will reappear in other guises.

As someone who's been a member of an industrial union, and as someone who's been an academic for a long time, I don't think the academics union will ever campaign, but I would rather see unions campaigning under their own names, using their own money, than doing it through, in a way, buying power within the Labor Party. I think I'm getting away from your question, I'm afraid. On the whole, I think this legislation will be beneficial, but we're going to have to suck it and see at the next election.

CHAIR: Mr Caldwell.

Mr CALDWELL: This is a little bit off the topic of what we've been talking about, this is about the configuration of the parliament. Do you have a view about the number of seats in the House of Reps or theories behind that?

Prof. Orr: I saw Professor Smith in Sydney the other day, and he said, 'You should bone up on the nexus question.' It's one of the more tedious things we teach in constitutional law. Our population is seven times what it was since federation, but the parliament is only two times what it was. I think there are some pretty strong arguments to say that the framers of the constitution intended for the parliament to grow. There are good reasons to suggest that constituency representation remains significant to a lot of people, and I don't know how I would be dealing with representing 150,000-plus people, because you are people not just electors. We complain about class sizes going up, but this is nothing compared to what has happened in the House.

Obviously, there are constitutional hurdles and issues here. I think one of the things we often don't talk about is that if we're going to increase the size of the Senate, that's obviously going to have political flow-ons for the quota and access to the Senate. I don't think that's necessarily a bad thing with the Senate being a more colourful representative house, if you like. When it comes to the size of the Senate and the nexus, one thing we don't often think about is that the intention, I think, was to ensure that there would be a significant pool of senators who could sit back more and be deliberative, and those senators would be available to be picked as frontbenchers and so on.

I think increasing the size of the parliament could also be helpful in some ways because you'll have more backbenchers, and we've reached a position in many parliamentary democracies where there's so many assistant ministers that that becomes, I think, a concern because of the nature of those roles and speaking up to the executive. There's no simple way around it, though. If you increase the size of House, you have to increase the size of the Senate.

I can only make two points. One is that it's not often suggested but you could have an odd number of senators. I think section 30 of the Constitution envisages that. It would just mean you would have different quotas at different half Senate elections. The other more odd or radical position, which I've advocated for in Queensland before, is that you could try and have a system of, if you like, deputy MPs. In the Queensland situation, part of the concern is that you've got these five massive seats, which phantom voters and so on. It's been suggested—and it wouldn't be a problem because Queensland doesn't have a strict constitution—you could have MPs and deputy MPs and those two people would run on a ticket together. One of them would have the right to sit in parliament, but you would have two people in an electorate to go around those massive electorates. There was going to be a court case earlier this year that didn't, in the end, get off the ground about job sharing. That was more, I think, from a feminist perspective. But that is one thing that could be thought about and discussed. If the real question is: how can you have the face of the MPs getting around electorates? That wouldn't necessarily involve increasing the formal size of the parliament, but obviously there would be more money and resources involved. Does anyone want to ask about fixed terms?

CHAIR: Ms Campbell, do you have a question on fixed terms?

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you very much. I note that Professor Orr said that he was a local. Can I say that you look like you come from a great place in Brisbane.

Prof. Orr: Great place? Oh, Moorooka! Yes, it's a very interesting and diverse community. I'm really glad to live there.

Ms CAMPBELL: I do have a couple of questions. The first is that the committee has had a number of discussions around behaviour at polling booths. There has been increased aggression at polling booths, but we've also had discussions around enforcement of sign regulation. I was interested in what you raised earlier around there being multiple bodies for enforcement in other jurisdictions. I'm interested in how that works, and does it work?

Prof. Orr: I was particularly referring to the realm of campaign and party finance—

Ms CAMPBELL: Correct.

Prof. Orr: If you look at ASIC and other bodies, they are strong regulators; whereas the Electoral Commission has tended to see itself more as an administrator of the logistics of elections per se. Half of my family are French and I've studied some of the French electoral system. There are very strong mandatory requirements on mayors to deal with their very strict rules about the posting of signs. The French are a rather demonstrative people, but they have very strict rules. You can only put up placards and signs on official metal noticeboards, which get trotted out by the mayoralties at election time.

In terms of violence and misconduct at elections, some prepolling stations are getting quite crowded and some polling stations on election day are getting quite sleepy, but I'm not particularly aware of anything other than, sometimes, bad behaviour by former students of mine, who seem to learn through student union elections that you get a little bit hyped on the day. I'm not sure that's a good part of the ritual of elections, but it's not something that I'm that concerned about. Certainly, I don't want to see police, which is obviously a feature, in many countries, that is a little bit austere.

Ms CAMPBELL: And what is your view on fixed terms?

Prof. Orr: Fixed terms? Yes, please! I'm much more sceptical of four-year terms. I wrote the 'no' case in the Queensland 2016 referendum, which Mr Neumann referred to, I think. I think it was only the Katter party that was campaigning with me for the 'no' case. It was 53-47, so it was reasonably clear.

The reason it got up—besides all the benefits of having the major parties and the business groups and the unions behind it—was that people liked the idea of fixed terms. They saw the propriety of not having snap elections in the hands of a prime minister or a premier. They didn't want longer terms. We only needed to have a referendum for longer terms in Queensland, not fixed terms. It was a case of bundling together something people wanted with something people didn't necessarily want—the way that telecommunications companies do—so it was very clever, but it wasn't the greatest of debates.

The reason I was against longer terms in Queensland was that we have a constitution very similar to that of the Northern Territory. There's no entrenched bill of rights. There's no upper house. We've got the *Courier Mail* to protect us! The Commonwealth is a bit different. You have an upper house, and, I think, despite the challenges in the media market, you have a lot more attention on Commonwealth and international politics.

One concern, obviously, with four-year terms is having eight-year Senate terms. They'd have to be four-year Senate terms. You'd have to have a referendum, though, to get that up.

If you want to have fixed terms, you can do a kind-of-British version. I know the Fixed-term Parliaments Act was considered a bit risible, but you could have some legislation that would provide some impediment to the prime minister's just calling a snap election. That would be largely a question of moral and political obligation because, obviously, if the governing party had control of the Senate or did a deal in the Senate, they could undo any of these impediments.

There would be some significant benefits, as I mentioned before, both for the planning of the Electoral Commission and also for other bodies, including Australia Post, if they had knowledge, well in advance, of the election date likely to be set.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you.

CHAIR: Thank you, Professor Orr, for your time today. If you've been asked to provide any additional information, please forward it to the secretariat by 9 January 2026. You'll be sent a copy of the transcript of your evidence, and we'll have the opportunity to request corrections to any errors.

Proceedings suspended from 12:53 to 14:01

BARTLEY, Mrs Merryl, Private capacity

FOREMAN, Mrs Joanne, Private capacity

LING, Mr Chek, Private capacity

ROSE, Mrs Pamela, Private capacity

TILEY, Ms Carmel, Private capacity

CHAIR: We will proceed to the community session. Participants in this session have been invited to give a five-minute statement to the committee. I'll invite participants to come to the table one at a time to give their statement. I would ask that participants to then remain at the table to briefly answer questions from the committee before we proceed to the next witness.

Although the committee does not require you to give evidence under oath, I should advise participants that this hearing is a legal proceeding of the parliament and therefore has the same standing as proceedings of the respective houses. The giving of false or misleading evidence is a serious matter and may be regarded as a contempt of parliament. The evidence given today will be recorded by Hansard and attracts parliamentary privilege. I now welcome Carmel Tiley to give evidence today. Do you have any comments to make on the capacity in which you appear?

Ms Tiley: I worked as a volunteer supporting Ellie Smith, the Independent in the Dickson electorate during the last campaign.

CHAIR: I now invite you to deliver your five-minute statement before we proceed to questions.

Ms Tiley: Thank you. Good afternoon, Mr Chairman and senators. My name is Carmel Tiley. I've been a resident of the Dickson electorate for over 40 years. During the 2025 federal election campaign, my husband and I joined the volunteer team for Independent candidate Ellie Smith. We were actively involved in various activities, including prepolling and election-day booths. While volunteering at Dickson's largest prepolling booth in Strathpine, which served over 17,000 voters, we experienced respectful and friendly interactions with all volunteers and candidates except for those from the LNP. They were openly hostile, refused to engage in any friendly conversation and often talked over us. They pushed in front of us to reach voters first, making loud comments about Ellie Smith, saying, 'She's really a Green,' or: 'She's a teal. She's not truly independent. She's backed by Climate 200 and Simon Holmes a Court.'

In the second week of prepolling the LNP began distributing a flyer that disparaged both the Greens and Ellie Smith, hiding it beneath their how-to-vote cards. They were telling voters, 'You really need to read this before you vote.' Elderly and frail voters, whom we assisted with close parking and safe access onto the path, often appeared overwhelmed when LNP volunteers pushed in front of us to guide them directly to the polling booth in a way that prevented them from collecting other candidates' flyers and instead had LNP flyers pressed into their hands.

The prepolling booth shared a carpark accessed by a narrow two-way driveway. We were instructed by the AEC booth captain to stand on the edge of the driveway to keep the path clear for voters, but many chose to walk along this driveway to avoid running the gauntlet past all the volunteers. When we raised safety concerns with the AEC booth captain, he dismissed them, stating his priority was the voters, and we were to direct them to the path. This created an unsafe environment for both voters and volunteers. Pedestrian access from the car park was uneven and lacked safety markings, causing several voters to stumble and one lady to fall. We took the initiative to install reflective yellow tape to highlight these hazards. Another elderly lady fell in the car park and sustained a head injury.

Despite our requests, the AEC booth captain delayed providing first aid assistance or access to the first aid kit. Eventually, a volunteer with first aid qualifications intervened and ensured the lady was taken to hospital. This incident highlights the need for comprehensive hazard assessments when selecting booth sites, accessible first aid kits and designated first aid officers who are not the AEC booth captain. Additionally, we recommend considering access to nearby toilet facilities for volunteers and candidates.

Each day of prepolling began with a rush to secure the best positions for signage. The LNP team captain and his tradie assistant added signs daily, including attaching corflutes high up light poles, using a ladder. Voters consistently commented on the overwhelming number of signs, saying this diluted individual candidate messages. We suggest implementing strict limits on the number of signs and volunteers at each booth, such as allowing only two volunteers and two signs per candidate.

Many voters also expressed concern about the wastefulness of how-to-vote flyers and plastic corflutes, concerned they were destined for landfill. A large number of voters chose not to take any flyers, saying they had

already made their decision or had the information on their phones. We recommend limiting how-to-vote instructions to one sign outside the booth entrance or one table containing all flyers for voters to collect if they wish.

While there was a recycling facility we were aware of for corflutes in Victoria, it quickly reached capacity, indicating a need for more corflute recycling sites to be established. We also advocate for a total ban on plastic bunting, especially at school sites, where the first party to arrive wraps entire fence lines to block other candidates' signage spaces.

Our team received several complaints about Ellie Smith campaign signs being placed improperly, such as in the middle of roundabouts or attached to telegraph poles. Strict records were kept of where we placed our signs. We knew they were not misplaced by our volunteers. There were also reports of signs going missing from supporters' yards. Social media trolling further questioned Ellie Smith's integrity based on these misplaced signs. An audit revealed that the number of incorrectly displayed signs exceeded the number reported stolen, leaving us somewhat puzzled.

On election day our team observed inconsistent enforcement of the six-metre rule at school polling booths. Some sites applied the rule outside the front gate, while others allowed entry into school grounds and applied the rule directly outside the voting space. It remains unclear whether the AEC or individual school principals are responsible for this decision.

Feedback from our team and from many voters strongly supports establishing fixed terms—possibly four years—for the federal parliament. This change would reduce prolonged media speculation and voter disengagement before elections. Additionally, with South-East Queensland's rapid population growth, there is a clear need to increase the number of elected representatives to ensure effective community representation.

In conclusion, we believe addressing these issues will help create a fairer, safer and more efficient electoral process for future elections. Thank you, Mr Chairman, for this opportunity.

CHAIR: Thank you, Ms Tiley. I appreciate your time in going through that submission, and I see you've gone through a lot of the terms of reference, which is really useful to us. I just want to clarify access to toilet facilities. Are you saying that the candidate and volunteers didn't have access to the toilet facilities within the grounds of the polling booth?

Ms Tiley: Within the grounds of our polling booth, there was no access to a toilet. There was one positioned within the polling booth building, which the captain allowed us to use a couple of times, if we were escorted, but then he decided no-one was going to use the toilet within the booth. Luckily, there was a hotel not far away and a shopping centre across the main road that people could use.

CHAIR: So the AEC stopped you? I understand you would've taken your campaign shirt off and all of that.

Ms Tiley: Correct.

CHAIR: And they stopped you using the bathroom?

Ms Tiley: Yes. Their excuse was that there were sensitive polling boxes stored within the vicinity of the toilet. There were screens around that, and there was only one toilet there. They said that one of their personnel would have to stand outside the door while we used the toilet, which I actually experienced once, and then after that it was just not worth it. We just took turns and went next door at the hotel.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Can I ask—was that Strathpine prepoll?

Ms Tiley: It was.

Senator MULHOLLAND: I was there a few times, and I experienced a similar situation.

CHAIR: You mentioned you volunteered at the 2025 election. Have you volunteered at previous elections as well, or was this your first time?

Ms Tiley: No, I hadn't.

CHAIR: It was your first time. Okay. We've received lots of evidence suggesting that voter experience in contested seats wasn't the best, this time around. I want to get an understanding from you, as a member of the community, of how important it is for Australians to have a positive or at least neutral experience when they go and vote.

Ms Tiley: I think it's extremely important. More and more people seem to be disengaging and were asking, 'How much is the fine if I don't have to vote?' That's because they didn't want to get into the incredibly long queue that existed for most of the time of prepolling. The numbers on actual election day were quite low in comparison. People seemed to be quite overwhelmed passing us volunteers, because there were so many of us, and because

they had to wait in the queue for so long. We got feedback from quite a lot of voters that they weren't really happy to be there because of the experience of the process.

CHAIR: I have many more questions, but I'll pass it on. Deputy Chair?

Senator COLBECK: Going back to your point around toilets in that particular site, did the polling officials say that it was based on requirements of the site itself or whether it was basically their determination? The reason I ask is that I saw that at other sites in my home state of Tassie, and it was more about the site itself or impositions from the owners of the site. In one case it was a school, for example. Or was it just a determination of the polling booth officials themselves?

Ms Tiley: My interpretation was that it was because of the positioning of where they were storing sensitive voting ballot boxes, which were in very close proximity to that toilet. It would have been specific to that site and the space that they had available to them to store sensitive material. It's a security aspect, from their perspective.

Senator COLBECK: I think we would get that side.

Ms Tiley: Yes.

Senator COLBECK: But it's not a unique experience, from what I've seen through the conduct of the election, particularly for campaign volunteers such as yourself. You said you were a first-time volunteer.

Ms Tiley: Yes.

Senator COLBECK: Do you think the system would benefit from a better definition of a polling booth? You described one place where it was the whole site and another where it was the front door. I've experienced exactly the same thing.

Ms Tiley: Or schools—yes.

Senator COLBECK: My understanding of the system and the act is that it's the determination of the booth captain from the AEC. But do you think the system would benefit from a better definition so that volunteers, such as yourself and others, would understand better how that operates, so there wasn't that confusion?

Ms Tiley: I would agree that, yes, clarification about that to make it clear for everybody would be a positive. In the case of the prepolling booth, the AEC captain seemed to be indicating that he only had control from within the building and that he didn't actually have control outside the building. That left us with a question of who was actually responsible for the voters and volunteers outside the physical building—in the carpark and on the waiting paths.

Senator COLBECK: In terms of the management of the site itself and the volume of material, how do you think that can be managed when all of that activity is outside the six-metre zone that is controlled by the AEC? How is that then managed when it's not within the responsibility of the AEC, as is how it currently stands? How do we manage that?

Ms Tiley: I think the question is that that is the current situation, and it needs to be looked at to find another process where either the AEC's oversight is extended or there's another level of policing or keeping track of how everything is happening outside.

Senator COLBECK: With respect to your comments in relation to LNP canvassers at the booth, and their allegations about Ms Smith and her being a Climate 200 candidate, do you know how much she received from Climate 200?

Ms Tiley: I don't know. I was not privy to that.

Senator COLBECK: But she did receive funding from Climate 200?

Ms Tiley: I believe, early in the campaign, there was something that was used, but I don't know what that was.

Senator COLBECK: The advice that I have from official numbers is $314,000 was put into her account.

Ms Tiley: That may be so, but I can't speak to that.

Senator COLBECK: Thank you.

CHAIR: Senator Mulholland.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Thank you, Ms Tiley. I, too, visited your polling booth a number of times and saw that incredibly long line of voters which didn't move for half an hour; there were some very agitated people. I want to go to your comments about fixed terms for four years. That particular prepoll location in the seat of Dickson, at Strathpine, is on a very busy road where you have to pull off suddenly. It's a very busy car park; it's very hard to get a park. There were a lot of people interacting with cars and it was very dangerous at times. Do

you think that a fixed term of four years would perhaps provide the AEC more opportunity to find safer, more appropriate locations for prepoll booths?

Ms Tiley: That may be the case. I was not clear about whose responsibility it was to decide on the polling booths. This polling booth has been used in the past; we have voted at that particular polling booth in past elections. My belief is it's not a suitable site. I would definitely be in favour of the parliament extending time and allowing the AEC the chance to find more suitable sites.

Senator MULHOLLAND: You also talked a little bit about some of the behaviour you witnessed. Being a first-time volunteer, that probably took you a bit by surprise—the behaviour of people on prepoll. Do you have any ideas about how we could improve the situation on prepoll or polling booths for volunteers when they are interacting with other parties? Do you have any ideas based on your experience there at Strathpine about how we could improve the situation for you, if you were to volunteer again, to make it safer and more enjoyable?

Ms Tiley: Part of the answer is to have fewer volunteers on site. At Strathpine there were way too many volunteers, and more turning up all the time. The sheer number of people just about tripping over each other caused an issue, in vying for position in that queue to, hopefully, get to voters first. That's probably happened at all elections, but it was very noticeable for the sheer number of volunteers that were present. Maybe, as volunteers, we need to agree to some code of conduct prior to manning a booth of volunteers, where we are expected to show equal respect to each other regardless of what party or candidate we're there to support.

Senator MULHOLLAND: There was some evidence this morning from another witness about an opportunity to register—so each candidate or party has a list of who is volunteering for them at that polling booth, what time they're showing up, their name and their number. The evidence we heard was about registering volunteers—not their number—and providing that to the AEC, saying, 'I'm candidate X, and today my volunteers on this booth will be these people,' so that there is some record inside the AEC of who you are, should there be incidents or issues.

Ms Tiley: I can see an advantage in that, although I know that, in our experience, people's situations would change sometimes from day to day with other responsibilities. They would say, 'Look, I can't be there at whatever time today, but I can come later,' or 'I can't be there today.' With people's lives, it can be a little bit challenging for some to commit to a particular timeslot in a timely fashion, to be able to notify the AEC.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Sure. I think that's fair advice. Thank you.

CHAIR: Dr Ryan.

Dr RYAN: Ms Tiley, you mentioned that you found that the people advocating for the LNP candidate were the most difficult. You didn't have any issues with people, for example, from other conservative parties, such as One Nation or the Trumpet of Patriots? Did they have candidates and representatives there?

Ms Tiley: Trumpet of Patriots didn't have anybody, and, no, we didn't have any issues with anybody else. Everybody got on really, really well. We were surprised at how well everybody got on. We could joke around with each other and we just respected each other. But, unfortunately, we just didn't feel, in this instance, that that was the behaviour of those there representing the LNP.

Dr RYAN: We're trying to work out how we can facilitate the engagement in the political process so everyone feels safe and welcome and enjoys it, whether they're volunteering for a party or for an Independent or whoever. Was there an obvious leader for the LNP candidate—someone who was there as the obvious head of the campaign—that you could talk to or appeal to when you were having issues?

Ms Tiley: There definitely was a team captain, but they were tarred with the same brush, basically. They just didn't engage. We would try to say hello to them, as we did to everybody else, and they would just ignore us as if we weren't there. It was quite bizarre, really.

Dr RYAN: I have just one other question. I think we're all really concerned to hear about the lady who had a fall and had an injury and that the AEC wasn't able to support her appropriately. Was the issue that the AEC representative didn't take responsibility for this issue, or was it that they didn't have the capacity to respond and assist this lady who had the fall in the car park? What was the issue there exactly?

Ms Tiley: While some team members attended to the lady in the car park, our team captain raced into the front door of the booth to notify the AEC captain, and he said that they'd have to wait until he was ready. They asked: could they use the first aid kit? And he said no. Eventually, one of the other volunteers from another group then said, 'I've got first aid.' He had his own first aid kit, so he, I think, challenged the AEC captain and then went ahead and dealt with it himself.

Dr RYAN: Thank you very much for that detail.

CHAIR: We're running out of time. Any questions, Mr Neumann?

Mr NEUMANN: With things like bunting and corflutes and signage, I got the impression—correct me if I'm wrong—that it just escalated. There was more and more, and every day there was more. Is that correct?

Ms Tiley: It is correct. We were laughing about it, really, because it was just like: 'Where are they going to put signs today?' There were no spaces left to put signs. At some stages there were one or two signs pulled down and others put in front of them, but when they started building them up the light poles because they were the only spaces on the site left, we were just incredulous and laughed about it because we just thought it looked so silly.

Mr NEUMANN: And what were the voters who were coming in saying to you about that increasing escalation of signage at the prepoll?

Ms Tiley: They were shaking their heads and saying, 'This is ridiculous.' A number of them said, 'This is ridiculous. There are so many signs. We can't even see what the message is because there are just so many.' It was just sign pollution.

Mr NEUMANN: Thank you.

CHAIR: Mr Caldwell.

Mr CALDWELL: Thanks for your time, Carmel. Did you do prepoll for the whole two weeks?

Ms Tiley: Yes, we did.

Mr CALDWELL: I'm sorry to hear about the experience with the toilets. My volunteers have suffered the same kind of exclusion—from prepolling locations in particular—which is quite distressing when you're giving up your time. Just in terms of the sheer number of people at these prepolls—you or someone said there were 17,000.

Ms Tiley: Yes.

Mr CALDWELL: If we said, 'Okay. Let's just say that half of that is an appropriate number of people,' would that have helped? What's your sense of the scale and magnitude of the number of voters that came through in a nine-day voting period? Was it just too many voters in one location, in terms of that part of it?

Ms Tiley: Yes, probably, because there were only a small number of prepolling sites across the electorate, and ours was obviously the largest one. Maybe if there were other sites available during prepolling, that would've spread the numbers out. I didn't hear from voters that they had an issue about going to the toilet. It was more us people who were there for hours, working as volunteers. It was lucky the hotel next door was quite happy for us to come traipsing in and out.

Mr CALDWELL: In terms of that feedback, do you think that the LNP or Labor people were getting the same feedback—'We don't like your signage'? Do you think the LNP voters who came in and saw their guy, and the Labor voters who saw their lady, who ultimately won, were happy to see their signage, and it was maybe just your supporters who were less happy with the signage generally?

Ms Tiley: These were people in the line, commenting as they're going in to vote, and I have no idea who they supported or who they voted for. These were just general voters who were making comments when they were lining up, before they even went in to vote.

Mr CALDWELL: Yes—just across the board.

Ms Tiley: Yes. So I have no idea who they were voting for.

Mr CALDWELL: Okay.

CHAIR: Mr Burnell?

Mr BURNELL: I find it interesting because in South Australia we don't tend to have some of these instances where there's a competition about who has the most corflutes in the garage to put up on polling day et cetera to—

CHAIR: That's because you're in a safe seat now. That's why.

Unidentified speaker: Yes. You're just not trying!

Mr BURNELL: outplay your opponents.

Members of the committee interjecting—

Mr BURNELL: Well, there are no convicts—

Members of the committee interjecting—

Mr BURNELL: We are the free state, Chair. I would like to draw it back to some common sense here.

You mentioned there was too much signage and too many volunteers at prepolling locations, and you suggested maybe a maximum of two corflutes and two volunteers or a volunteer per candidate. I'm inclined to think that there need to be some restrictions on corflute material, and maybe the number of volunteers needs to be maxed at polling booths. But do you think it would be reasonable to say that, if there's more than one entry point to the polling booth, you need to have more than just one or two? If you get too prescriptive about the total number of volunteers allowed at any one location, you potentially diminish the voter experience by the sheer lack of ability to engage with anyone from a chosen political party.

Ms Tiley: I take your point, yes. At our prepolling booth, there were two directions of entry for voters. One was from the footpath on the main road. They had to park across the road, in the shopping centre, and then walk across and join the queue there. The other entry was via the rear car park. Then they had to come past us and join that queue at the front of the building. So, yes, we had two points of entry for voters for them to reach the one entryway into the polling booth.

Mr BURNELL: The other thing—I want to draw on your experience as a voter, not as a volunteer. In previous elections, when you'd go into a polling booth, maybe a prepoll location, what were the polling booths like in 2022 and 2019, going back in time? Was there noticeably less material at the polling booths? Is this a standalone or is this just something that's synonymous with Queensland politics?

Ms Tiley: No. There was still, in my past experience, a larger number of signs than they really needed. It was still fairly cluttered, but certainly not to the same extent that it was this past election. Obviously, it was unique. It's a unique seat. It was a unique battle. It was do or die, I think, for some of the candidates, so I think they just went all out.

Mr BURNELL: Okay. Thank you.

Senator COLBECK: Did the signs go up and down every day and night?

Ms Tiley: To begin with, they did. Then, after a few days, groups started leaving their signs up mostly. There were some key ones that they pulled down, but they left others there. But then, by the end, they were staying up and being added to every day.

Senator COLBECK: Thanks.

CHAIR: Thank you, Ms Tiley. We appreciate your time today.

Ms Tiley: Thank you, Chair, for the opportunity.

CHAIR: I now call upon Mrs Merryl Bartley. Do you have any comments to make on the capacity in which you appear?

Mrs Bartley: I volunteered for Ellie Smith in the federal campaign.

CHAIR: Thank you, Mrs Bartley. I now invite you to deliver your five-minute statement before we proceed to questions.

Mrs Bartley: I volunteered as a booth captain for Independent candidate Ellie Smith during prepoll in Dickson, Peter Dutton's electorate. This booth processed more than 13,000 voters, the second-highest volume in the electorate. The layout was cramped, with only two footpath entry points between garden beds, which made the voter experience quite congested.

From the first day, the LNP established an early and dominant presence. They installed large permanent billboards just outside the six-metre line and set up dozens of corflutes along the road, in car parks and right up the pathways to the centre. Once other candidates arrived and placed their own signage, the space became visually overwhelming. Voters were funnelled through a narrow corridor of volunteers handing out how-to-vote cards, and many expressed discomfort and frustration. The most common feedback we heard was about visual clutter, waste, excessive volume of material and running the gauntlet. A significant number of voters declined all material—especially younger ones, who usually had the information on their phones. Our own campaign was left with a large excess of unused printed material.

Some behaviour went beyond signage. The LNP positioned volunteers directly beside the disability parking spaces. Elderly voters often had how-to-vote cards shoved into their hands before they even got out of the car, and they were then walked past the rest of us, giving the impression that no-one else could have access to give them how-to-vote material.

For several days a group of young men, dressed similarly and acting as a coordinated unit, attended in LNP T-shirts. They were highly vocal and approached voters in an overly enthusiastic and sometimes intimidating way. A booth captain from another location reported a similar group there as well. I can't confirm whether they belonged to a particular organisation, but their presence was noteworthy.

Throughout the prepoll period, the LNP maintained at least six volunteers on site at all times. Their conduct towards other volunteers was often hostile. Remarks, such as, 'She's a green,' or, 'You don't know who's backing her,' were directed at voters taking material from us.

The treatment of Greens volunteers was worse. The LNP distributed a misleading leaflet misrepresenting Greens policies and implying support from the Independent and Labor candidates. Their booth captain actively promoted this material to voters waiting in long queues. I have a copy if you need it, though I'm sure you've seen it at some stage.

Beyond conduct, there were safety concerns. The access from the disability spaces included a raised step with broken kerbing. Several voters tripped and one person fell and sustained a cut. AEC staff said that they didn't have a first aid kit and they made no attempt to assist. Volunteers from another party provided support, and the voter declined QAS attendance. It raises questions about responsibilities and whether polling places should have designated first aid resources. Similarly, polling locations should be evaluated for suitability. On election day, the school principal at my booth refused volunteers access to toilet facilities, an issue both practical and avoidable.

Concerns were also raised regarding mobile voting at aged-care facilities. The facilities manager at my aunt's residence reported that residents received no candidate information or how-to-vote materials. Many residents there are highly engaged and value their voting rights, yet felt disadvantaged due to a lack of accessible information.

Based on these experiences, I'd suggest the following changes. Limit volunteers to two per candidate at a time, or one per entry point. Limit signage to three or four corflutes per candidate, and ban plastic bunting. Provide a clearly visible table with all candidates' how-to-vote cards so voters may choose independently. Reduce the prepoll period to one week to avoid voters missing late campaign information. Ensure aged-care and supported-accommodation polling includes accessible candidate information. Also, the AEC could provide a volunteer conduct guide, distributed at booths, clarifying rules around signage, behaviour, boundaries and the authority of AEC staff. The AEC could partner with schools to strengthen education about our electoral system, especially about preferential voting, which so many people do not understand, and improve digital literacy so that voters can better distinguish fact from opinion. Overall, these adjustments would help create a fairer, safer and more respectful voting environment, one that upholds not just the mechanics of democracy but the spirit of it. Thank you.

CHAIR: Thank you, Mrs Bartley. We really appreciate your evidence today. I have a few questions regarding the conduct guide. It's a theme we've heard a lot about in evidence. When you volunteered for Ms Smith, did she or her team train you on how to conduct yourself during election day, on what to avoid and what to do?

Mrs Bartley: Absolutely. We had a code of conduct. We were all made aware that how we behaved reflected on our candidate, and we were very conscious of that. Everyone had to sign that they had read the code of conduct.

CHAIR: Was it made clear to you that, if you didn't abide by this code, certain actions would be taken? Or, if you signed it, were you just expected to abide by it?

Mrs Bartley: That's a good question. We just assumed that we would all do it, I think. We just thought, 'We're adults; we'll do that.'

CHAIR: Sure. I think that's an assumption we all make until we witness behaviour that falls foul of what we all expect at polling booths. Do you think a similar process administered by the AEC, as you've suggested, where, if someone were to volunteer at an election booth, they would need to read and sign a code of conduct or abide by certain rules, would help improve behaviour at booths?

Mrs Bartley: Possibly, but then who's going to enforce it? And who has the resources to enforce it, and what would the penalties be? That's a hard one to answer.

CHAIR: If the AEC were well resourced, would they be best placed to do that? I'll let you know that they don't want to. But do you feel like they're best placed to do it, or would it need to be someone else?

Mrs Bartley: Is there a way to make sure that, when candidates nominate to run for an election, they have a code of conduct in place? I'm not sure. One of the earlier witnesses said, 'Humans are going to be humans.'

CHAIR: You said that you weren't able to identify the grouping of 'young men'. Were they a third party, with non-party material on, or were they wearing the material of a candidate?

Mrs Bartley: They were wearing LNP T-shirts. I have my suspicions about which organisation they came from. Frankly, they looked like they came out of a factory. They all looked the same.

CHAIR: Was there a coordinated attendance at prepoll booths on election day as well or just prepoll?

Mrs Bartley: No, just prepoll.

CHAIR: Deputy Chair.

Senator COLBECK: How many volunteers did you have on the booth?

Mrs Bartley: We tried to have four. It didn't very often work out that way, because, with people being volunteers, you can't make them turn up, but we tried to roster four.

Senator COLBECK: Do you think it should be limited to less than that?

Mrs Bartley: Yes, I do.

Senator COLBECK: What's the basis of you wanting to lessen that? I mean, you had four; you had four because that's what you could manage, basically. Is that right?

Mrs Bartley: Yes, probably, but once you get down to the practicalities of it, at the actual site, there was so little room for people. There were narrow footpaths and two entrances to come in. Can you imagine, if it's this wide and someone's standing each side of it thrusting things at you?

Senator COLBECK: You did mention running the gauntlet. I understand what you're talking about there, so I do get that. You said most people declined material, particularly younger people. What proportion actually took material from the people that were handing it out?

Mrs Bartley: That's a very good question. It would be less than half, probably significantly less than half.

Senator COLBECK: Do you think that most younger people had it on their phone—if they wanted something, they had it on their phone?

Mrs Bartley: Yes. Our experience was that the ones that were keen to get it were LNP voters, and all they took was an LNP leaflet.

Senator COLBECK: That's interesting. Your comments about aged care comes from one specific site.

Mrs Bartley: Yes.

Senator COLBECK: It's an important point, though, making sure senior Australians are not disenfranchised. How do you think you appropriately managed that, given all the conversation you've had around your experience on prepoll? This is a particular element of that process. How do you think it should be properly managed so that people who are living in a residential aged-care facility and are still quite engaged in what's going on are not disenfranchised as a part of the electoral process, given that's the basis of what we're talking about here today?

Mrs Bartley: Perhaps the AEC, when they come out with their mobile booths, could provide how-to-vote cards for each candidate. But then they would have to appear non-partisan, wouldn't they? I don't know. In the end, it's up to the candidates to make sure that that information is provided to all the facilities in their electorate.

Senator COLBECK: So your perspective based on your personal experience would be that, in the case of that particular facility, that wasn't available to the residents who were interested and engaged and would have been curious to take up the information if it were there.

Mrs Bartley: Yes, very much.

CHAIR: Senator Mulholland.

Senator MULHOLLAND: I have no specific questions. Mrs Bartley, I just want to note that your comments around first-aid kits and their availability at prepolling booths and training of staff was a really good call out.

Mrs Bartley: Thank you.

CHAIR: Dr Ryan.

Dr RYAN: Mrs Bartley, I appreciate your submission and your contribution today. We only had two prepoll sites in my electorate, but one of them was also a prepoll site for two adjoining electorates which added to congestion but also added to the number of candidates who wanted to have representatives present at the prepoll site. Was that the case in Dickson?

Mrs Bartley: At our polling booth, we had a Senate candidate, and there was another candidate from another electorate where people could vote.

Dr RYAN: Would you accept or agree that, if we change the rules, as you've suggested, and an Independent candidate could have two signs, and, potentially, two or three candidates from other parties could then have two signs if the prepoll site is covering more than one electorate, and there are signs for Senate candidates as well, the Independent's two little corflutes might be overwhelmed by party related signage, even if there are only two signs for each candidate from each party?

Mrs Bartley: That's certainly possible. I think there were seven candidates in Dickson, so, theoretically, there would have been at least 14. I think I said two volunteers but three or four corflutes per candidate. So it's getting even worse, isn't it?

Dr RYAN: It is, isn't it? It's a bit of a wicked problem. We've heard from many people from different electorates around these issues with prepoll and the congestion there and the long waits and the issues related to that. Did you experience any similar issues on polling day, on election day itself, where there are often a much larger number of sites?

Mrs Bartley: No, there were not as many signs. Also, it was a school ground, so it was much more open. There were just a trickle of voters all day. It was very boring, actually.

Dr RYAN: Yes, it can get like that. So would you agree with the suggestion that we perhaps should have fewer polling sites on election day but more prepoll sites in the lead-up?

Mrs Bartley: Yes, I think so. Really, there were only a couple of times where people had to actually queue to go in to vote on election day itself, whereas we had queues for up to an hour at the prepoll. Also, the first week of prepoll was a lot slower than the second week because everyone thinks, 'I've got two weeks to do this.' They put it off and put it off.

Dr RYAN: You mentioned a group of young men who you said looked very similar to each other and that you suspected that they were from a specific group. To clarify, was your suspicion that these young men were representatives of the Exclusive Brethren?

Mrs Bartley: It's my suspicion, for which I have no evidence, that they were Brethren.

Dr RYAN: Thank you.

CHAIR: Ms Campbell.

Ms CAMPBELL: My question follows on from the previous member's questions. In terms of the people that you talked about, who you believe to be representing a third party, you used the phrase, 'They look like they came out of a factory.' Can you take us through the characteristics that they had that made you feel like they looked like they came out of a factory?

Mrs Bartley: They were in their early 20s, I would say. They were very clean cut. They all wore—it probably sounds odd—those long skinny shorts. They all had the LNP t-shirts. They were all very well groomed. You could hardly tell them apart. You thought, 'Did I see this one before or not?' But when you saw them all as a group—

Ms CAMPBELL: Do you know if they arrived together?

Mrs Bartley: I think they did. They suddenly appeared as this group of people came in.

Ms CAMPBELL: How did they act?

Mrs Bartley: They were very effusive and very loud in greeting people. It put people off, actually, because it was more like what you would expect to see in the US with that sort of over-the-top effusiveness and fake friendliness.

Ms CAMPBELL: Did they seem organised? Did they say the same things?

Mrs Bartley: I don't know that they had a particular spiel. It was just that they were very aggressive in getting to people first and giving them their leaflets, their how-to-votes.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you very much. I appreciate it.

CHAIR: Thank you very much, Mrs Bartley. Joanne Foreman, I now invite you to deliver your five-minute statement before we proceed to questions.

Mrs Foreman: No, I don't have a statement. I've submitted my submission. You've received that?

CHAIR: I didn't have any questions based on your submission. Did anyone else have any questions?

Dr RYAN: What brings you here today? What was it about the election in 2025 specifically that you feel that you'd like to discuss with the committee? What are your top three suggestions for how we can make the Australian electoral experience better?

Mrs Foreman: I did prepolling for two weeks before the election plus polling day. I've just heard the last lady. My experience was a little bit similar. Polling day petered out about four o'clock, but we were open till six. Hardly anybody was coming through at that point in time. If they were, we were cheering, almost. But, during prepoll, the polling officer, the officer in charge, told us that he couldn't close the gates until six o'clock under the law or the rules, but our line was already longer than it had ever been in the last few days. People were actually

out on the street. We had to tell them, 'If you're here, you're probably going to wait two hours to get in.' That's how long it was at that point in time, in those last couple of evenings. Some people turned away to go on Saturday, and other people stayed, but it seemed ridiculous that it took that long. I was at Broadwater Road at Mansfield at the church there, and the officer told us that they had increased the number of—I don't know what they're called—people who write out the voting slips for them. So they were increased across the two weeks, but still, on those last few days, it was a terrible waiting time.

Dr RYAN: Would you agree, then, that it might be sensible to consider, if we're going to allow people to vote at prepoll, having more prepoll sites and perhaps rationalise the number of sites that we have on election day?

Mrs Foreman: It seems sensible. I don't know why people came to prepoll, because I don't think you had to give a reason by that point in time. I think at other prepolls you had to give a reason, but not this one. I'm not certain.

Dr RYAN: I think there's some inconsistency about that. That's a question that's supposed to be asked, but a few people who have talked to the committee have told us that they don't believe that the question has been asked where they are. It's not enforced anyway. Do you have any other suggestions for how we can improve the process?

Mrs Foreman: In my submission, I did say that I thought that we should only have a couple of candidate representatives per pathway into the booth. Where I was at, we didn't really have an overwhelming amount, but, not during the federal election but during the previous state election, we had people who were third party come in and were a bit obnoxious.

Dr RYAN: Was there any group that was particularly obnoxious, or was the obnoxiousness across the board?

Mrs Foreman: No, no. It was a group called the Coalition of Working Families, authorised by Alex Scott. There was a man or woman dressed up as a weasel—so big! This was during the state election. He plodded in with about eight other men and women dressed in purple shirts with this Coalition of Working Families. They came up very close to our candidate, and some of the other volunteers moved away. I thought, 'Oh, I can't leave her there all by herself.' So I moved over next to her, and she said: 'Don't worry. I've had worse.' They were quite loud. They did leave after a while.

Dr RYAN: One would imagine that in Queensland a weasel costume would be poorly tolerated after a period of time. No?

Mrs Foreman: It was pretty hot. I don't know how they did it.

Dr RYAN: Thank you.

CHAIR: Senator Mulholland, do you have some questions?

Senator MULHOLLAND: Thank you, Mrs Foreman. You mentioned that you were volunteering on prepolling for a couple of weeks. Were you volunteering for a particular candidate or party?

Mrs Foreman: Yes. The LNP.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Have you volunteered in previous elections? You mentioned the state election with Mr Weasel. Have you been on previous federal campaigns?

Mrs Foreman: I volunteered for the yes/no referendum at exactly the same place for prepoll, and the lines weren't anywhere near as long as these, and everyone was really great to work with there, on both the yes and no sides. I volunteered with the LNP not at prepoll but only on polling day in 2022.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Have you noticed any differences between campaigning in 2022 to 2025 in your seat? Which seat is yours? Would that be down—

Mrs Foreman: Bonner. I actually didn't. We had a lot of those signs that they put up along the fences. I think maybe there were more third-party signs, but that would be all. I didn't—when you wrote here that there was increased aggressive conduct, I thought, 'Really?' I had to look it up.

Senator MULHOLLAND: The committee has been to Victoria and New South Wales and has heard significant reports of that. I joined Mr Neumann out at his booths at Blair here in Queensland and witnessed it for myself—written, verbal and physical. It sounds like you were at a lovely booth there, Mrs Foreman. You were at the pick of the booths, by the sounds of it and very fortunate, because we have seen some pretty bad behaviour. My final question was just around third-party volunteers. We heard from a previous witness about groups of people showing up, looking like they were sort of all together from different groups. Did you have that experience on your booth there in Bonner?

Mrs Foreman: No, not for the federal election.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Thank you very much.

CHAIR: Any further questions? Mr Burnell.

Mr BURNELL: On page 2, your recommendation No. 4, 'exclude third-party players from the candidate representative area'—are you calling for the exclusion of anybody that's not directly affiliated with a candidate outside of a certain predetermined zone within a polling booth or—

Mrs Foreman: In my mind, if it's a school, then the candidates' assistance can be in the school grounds, but the third parties need to have to stay outside the school grounds.

Mr BURNELL: If that weren't a school and, say, it were church grounds or a community centre, which is often the case in some areas, then it can't be within, say, 200 metres of that entry point or something like that?

Mrs Foreman: Yes. Something like that. Something easy. I think that would alleviate a lot of the problems associated with asking the AEC to look after the issues—if that were dispersed a bit more.

Mr BURNELL: Thank you.

CHAIR: Thanks for your time today, Mrs Foreman. I now welcome Chek Ling. Thank you so much, sir. I'm not sure if you were here when I read this out before, so I'm going to read it again, just in case. Although the committee does not require you to give evidence under oath, I should advise participants that this hearing is a legal proceeding of the parliament and therefore has the same standing as proceedings of the respective houses. The giving of false or misleading evidence is a serious matter and may be regarded as a contempt of parliament. The evidence given today will be recorded by Hansard and attracts parliamentary privilege. You're now invited to deliver a five-minute statement before we go to questions.

Mr Ling: Thank you, Chair. Until 10 o'clock this morning, I thought that I had written my swan song. Since 10 o'clock, I've been asked to sing it, but I suspect you have already read it. So, I will just talk to you on two or three words and let you challenge me on my conclusions, suggestions and observations.

I'm an electrical engineer by training. I did an MBA. That's when I got interested in the Labor Party. I came across a book by TH Kewley, then reader in politics at Sydney University. In his book, he claimed that all the major social policies implemented in Australia were done by the Labor government. Today, it is my swan song. I'm 84. All I worry about is the country—the homeland I can bequeath to my grandchildren.

At 10 o'clock this morning, I was cleaning the showers in readiness for the invasion of Christmas. What have I got to say to you? Three words. Courage, integrity and imagination. We need the courage to look at the elephant in the room that is doing so much damage to our democracy. You can read my justification for saying that in my paper. We need the courage to question whether the two-party-preferred system has outlived its functional capacity.

As you know, the last election yielded some unexpected results. For the layman, one vote for the ALP is worth 32 votes for the Greens. That is one calculation you can make on the actual results of the election. As I say, I'm an engineer. I also did marketing in my MBA, so I know figures can lie, but I haven't concocted this figure just for fun. It is enough for you people to take it on board and say, 'Okay, where do we go from here?' It's crook. The Greens need 32 votes for every Labor vote cast for a share of a seat in the house of parliament. That's not cricket under any country's terms.

The other thing about our politics is the duopoly. As I've written, the duopoly can conspire to ram through legislation they like, either for their own purposes or to weed out the teals, these 'nuisance people'. Also, there's the fear of the party in parliament of offending big money and important people in society, like Alan Jones, because they might be able to get you some votes or something like that. You can read all that in my paper.

The other thing I want to talk about is integrity. The rogue elephant is the two-party-preferred system. We have to change it, because all the yields of our political behaviour come from that. It is adversarial. It is 'winning is everything', or, as Graham Richardson might say, 'whatever it takes'. What he really meant is 'whatever you can get away with'. If you don't know Graham's origin story, he really is a criminal. But we gave him a state funeral. Is that a good example of a political system to bequeath to the younger generation, to the generation of my grandchildren? I doubt it.

And imagination, please. The last chair of this committee wrote that proportional representation is too far from what we practice: 'We can't do it,' so she ought not recommend it. Instead, she threw in the lolly that everybody likes—increase the number of MPs in the parliament. Of course, that has borne fruit, because it's in the papers now that this is what Senator Don Farrell wants, and of course you've got people like Andrew Bartlett saying, 'Take it up to 200.' That is music to the faction leaders. As a Labor Party member of 20 years standing, I know how the faction system works. That is really all I have to say.

Please think of what is good for your grandchildren. When they come of age, what will they think of what you have done? Have you grappled with the opportunity that is in front of you, or are you completely weighed down by party politics and needing to think about your next career, your next move or whatever? I'm sorry I'm not polite, but at 84 and being an immigrant—by accident, by the way—I feel that it is my duty to speak the truth to the matter for the sake of my grandchildren.

I may be a bit self-indulgent. You may have heard Yo-Yo Ma, the famous international cellist, speaking on American TV. It takes three generations for an immigrant to establish their roots in the soil of their adopted country home. My grandchildren are doing all right, but I will be so worried about the sort of political system we have which might get them being sent to a foreign war, just like what Menzies did unilaterally, more or less, sending those people to Vietnam.

Mr Chair and members, thank you for the opportunity. I hope you will consider the courage, the integrity and the imagination to bring about proportional representation.

Let me just add, in *Annabel Crabb's Civic Duty*, the documentary, she went to Denmark, a nation of six million people. It looks like they have had proportional representation for many years, if not a hundred. My short-term memory is very bad, so I read these things and I don't remember for a long time. The beautiful image you have of that is—maybe it was the speaker of the house or someone like that who was talking to her in Denmark. Annabel Crabb showed, on her phone, the raucous we have in parliament, and this person said: 'In Denmark, this would never happen. The speaker, when he speaks, everybody goes silent.' I thank you.

CHAIR: Thank you, Mr Ling. And thank you for choosing to sing your song here at the Hotel Grand Chancellor.

Mr Ling: Of course. I forgot that you were going to come.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Now comes the fun bit!

CHAIR: Yes. I've got your submission here. You referred to some of it in your evidence just there. I want to understand point 1, where you said the ALP won 94 seats with 34.56 per cent of the first votes and the Greens won just one seat with 12.2 per cent of the votes. You then go on to say parties are getting less than 40 per cent of votes, but then the teals burst out on the scene in 2022. I just want to understand. In our electoral system in the lower house, you don't elect people based on national vote, yet there's always this comparison to the national vote when it comes to commenting on how parties or participants have performed at the election. For example, in my seat, I got a 45 per cent primary. Why do you think we should look at a national vote to determine the outcome of an election when our system doesn't and has never used a national vote to elect members of parliament? Why is this given so much weight in your submission but also by electoral commentators? By the same measure, independents received between 10 and 12 per cent of the vote, but they've got—why should these numbers have an impact on our system when they're not used to elect members?

Mr Ling: I don't really quite understand your question, but let me let me answer you as honestly and as best I can. The number 50—is it good or bad? If it is a passing point, 51 is good. If it's not a passing point, it is not good. As I say, with the number I computed, 32 green volts is worth only one ALP volt as far as getting the number of MPs in the parliament is concerned.

CHAIR: But we don't use the national vote to get into parliament.

Mr Ling: That doesn't matter.

CHAIR: Well, it does. That's not how we get people elected.

Mr Ling: I'm talking about democracy. I don't know what you're talking about. If we are talking about democracy, one vote has one value, okay? That is the ideal of the canon of democracy—one vote, one value. But we don't have it here. It's staring you in the face. If we've got 12 per cent of the vote and just one seat in Parliament, that is—

Mr BURNELL: Wouldn't the argument then be that it's the responsibility of individual parties to put up candidates that the public resonate with and therefore vote for? That's what we've seen in seats where we've got independents elected.

Mr Ling: To me, that is not a real argument. That is just saying that, based on the current system, this is what the minor parties have to do to get in. You can say, 'Well, the teals got in.' Yes, teals got in. Some of them got this much margin. Look at Adam Bandt. He is gone. So the two-party preferred system is very good at preserving the two parties but no good in terms of flourishing the democracy that we should have.

Nobody is going to argue that the teals are not good quality candidates. They are a cut above the average in the parliament. But you can't use the exception as the rule. Just because the teals get in does not mean that you can

have good candidates that will get in from the Greens or Pauline Hanson or whatever. The truth of the matter is that there are many scholars writing on proportional representation. If you care to read the submissions from them—for example, the 2022 submissions—you will find that very knowledgeable people have written on this and why it is good. At the last assessment by the Proportional Representation Society of Australia, if we had proportional representation according to their model, the Labor Party would have, I think, 59 members, the Liberals would have 60 and the Greens would have 21. Now, to me, that accords more with the sentiment of the voting public because only a third of them—one in three—vote for one of the two major parties. Now, do we have the courage, do we have the integrity to look at the real-world elephant in the room, which is the two party system? The two-party-preferred system is like two mafia bosses fighting for their gains. Nothing else matters, you know. Ask Graham Richardson.

Senator COLBECK: So your argument—I come from Tassie, where we have a completely different system—

Mr Ling: I'm sorry, can you say that again? My hearing is very bad.

Senator COLBECK: I come from Tasmania, where our electoral system is effectively the inverse of what we have at a federal system. If you're looking at the voting for the Senate, we have, effectively, a proportional representation system by state.

Mr Ling: Can we not talk about the Senate? The Senate is quite different, because each of the states—

Senator COLBECK: I'm a senator, so I have an interest! And I'm going to talk about it because it is relevant to your discussion. Effectively, in the Senate, we do have a proportional representation system, and the makeup of the Senate is reflective of that. In Tasmania, where I live, our lower house system has proportional representation at an electorate level. The state is still divided up into electorates, and we have seven members elected from each electorate. The vote required to get elected, I think, is 12.6 per cent or something of that nature, and we have five Greens, 13 or 14 Liberals, 10 Labor and five or six Independents in the 35-seat parliament. So it is the same. It is a proportional system as you talk about. So what you're advocating, effectively, is that we should flip our system or change our system in the lower house to how the Senate operates. But then what do we do with the upper house? That is in a system that is proportionately elected in the way that you're describing.

Mr Ling: I understand. I think that, with proportional representation for the lower house, it is going to be different from the Senate because the Senate is based on state. Every state has so many members. In a lower house with proportional representation, it will based on the number of voters in each election.

Senator COLBECK: Yes, but the principles apply equally. It really comes down to how many people are being elected per electorate or per region and therefore the hurdle that is required to get elected, which is the quota. In the Tasmanian parliament, you need at least 12 per cent. In a partially preferential voting system—it's not a full preferential voting system anymore—it is effectively the inverse of what we have at a national level. That's what you're advocating for—that our lower house should be effectively like Tasmania's, which is described as the most democratic process in the country. I think I'm on the same page as you.

Mr Ling: Yes, it is. The Proportional Representation Society of Australia recommends proportional representation and a single transferable vote. Now, I'm no expert at all on the subject, but I know enough. I agree with you; it would be exactly how the Tasmanian lower house works.

Senator COLBECK: Your view is that that would be better for democracy in this country?

Mr Ling: That would be much better for democracy because people like the Greens will be elected. At the moment, I think it is a disgrace that you've only got one Greens member in the lower house. Twelve per cent of the country voted for the Greens.

Senator COLBECK: Yes, and they've got how many senators?

Senator MULHOLLAND: Eleven.

Senator COLBECK: They've lost a couple, haven't they? Careless.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Some went to greener pastures.

Senator COLBECK: So to speak.

CHAIR: I'm wary of time.

Senator COLBECK: Okay. Mr Ling, I think I understand where you're coming from.

CHAIR: Dr Ryan.

Dr RYAN: One of the issues with MMP representation, or that sort of system, is its complexity. We might have some difficulty socialising it and having it accepted by the Australian population, were we to seriously

consider changing to MMP as opposed to proportional representation. How would you suggest that sort of education and socialisation be undertaken?

Mr Ling: I am sure there would be lots of people who could help do that. The only thing that I can go on, being an engineer, is to look at the result—at what is possible, and where the facilities and resources are. We know New Zealand has it. They've had it for 20 or 30 years, or something like that. As you know, the Tasmanian lower house has it. And we know Denmark has it. If you read what the Proportional Representation Society of Australia has written, you will know that many countries in the world have proportional representation. We talk about a fair go. Bloody hell! Was it a fair go when the Greens, who polled 12 per cent, got one seat—one who barely sneaked in? And, for a lot of the teals, when the weather changes a bit, they're on the blink. The effort and the money they have to put in to get elected is a disgrace to a democracy. It's a complete disgrace, in my view. I'm an engineer and I talk about bang for your buck. But it is a disgrace. Now, when politicians get elected, the next thing they do is host a function for fundraising. What a cultural disgrace.

CHAIR: Any further questions, members?

Ms CAMPBELL: Yes. I understand that your argument is that the Greens should have more seats because of the nature of their vote. What was the percentage that you said they had?

Mr Ling: They got 12 per cent.

Ms CAMPBELL: How many seats do you believe that they should have, on that basis?

Mr Ling: According to the Proportional Representation Society of Australia's model, which they have used for many years, the Greens would get 21.

Ms CAMPBELL: So 21 per cent on the basis of 12 per cent. I take it that you would also support One Nation having significantly more of those seats because they're currently polling at 17 per cent. Do you believe that One Nation should have about 30 seats?

Mr Ling: I believe that the people's will should be implemented.

Ms CAMPBELL: Is it your position that One Nation should have 30 seats under the system?

Mr Ling: No, not at all.

Ms CAMPBELL: Okay.

Mr Ling: My position is that Pauline Hanson's party should have nothing because they're a complete disgrace. The only reason that they're doing so well is that we've completely mismanaged the economy and mismanaged our social infrastructure. You have all these despondent people looking for a saviour. They say, 'Here's my saviour.' It's a bit like Trump in America.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you very much, Chek. I appreciate it.

CHAIR: Thank you, Chek. Thanks for your time today. We've got one final witness. I now call Mrs Pamela Rose. Do you have any comments to make on the capacity in which you appear?

Mrs Rose: I'm here under a personal capacity, but I did also work at the last election on a campaign.

CHAIR: Thank you very much. Excellent. I now invite you to deliver your five-minute statement before we proceed to questions.

Mrs Rose: Thank you for the opportunity to appear. I wish to speak to two very important reforms: an expansion of parliament and the adoption of fixed terms. Australia has outgrown its current parliament size. Our population has almost doubled since the early eighties, yet the number of federal representatives has not. MPs and senators are overloaded. It is fair to argue they cannot always do their jobs as well as they should because the capacity and staffing simply are not there, more so for Independents and minor parties. If we want a strong democracy, we need a parliament built for the number of its citizens. Expansion is part of that. More members means better scrutiny, stronger committees and more time spent on real parliamentary work rather than juggling impossible workloads. Critics will say politicians don't do a good job and ask why we need more. The reality is that electorate offices cannot meet the demands of, on average, 120,000 constituents. This change means being able to manage the direct requests from constituents in a more timely manner and properly serve communities.

The second reform is fixed terms. This matters because our current system allows election timing to be used strategically to benefit the government of the day. Governments can go early when a poll looks favourable or when the opposition is unprepared. That is not a contest of ideas. That is a contest of timing. It undermines trust in the fairness of our elections and turns it into a game. Australians simply deserve better. It also weakens accountability. When a government can avoid scrutiny by pulling the election trigger early, the public loses the steady, predictable cycle that keeps everyone honest.

The uncertainty in our federal cycle has real consequences. As a campaign manager at the last election, I saw firsthand how this plays out. Not knowing how long to rent an office space, hire consultants or organise advertising for or when to plan events makes it difficult and expensive to campaign. With the new caps on donations, it is even more important to not waste money on limbo campaigning. We should want genuine competition for seats, because we want the best representatives serving Australians. Using election timing to make it harder for the competition is not in the public interest, and governments should not wield that power.

This impact reaches everyday Australians too. Public servants, electorate staff and AEC staff operate in a constant state of readiness. Many cannot plan holidays or family events, and work-life balance is left in chaos. Some hesitate to sign contracts and have little confidence in how long the job they hold will last because the political timetable might shift overnight. Even schools feel it. Principals delay planning events, because they are often used for election day, and P&C groups cannot confidently organise in advance so much as a sausage sizzle or fundraiser because they cannot plan ahead. Communities are thrown into uncertainty for purely political reasons. Voters also endure long election run-ups because the timeline is never clear. Then you have big business, with projects being put on ice because they want certainty that a change in government would not be the death of a project.

These reforms are not cosmetic. They are courageous, and they will be judged as history making. Expanding parliament lifts capacity of service. Fixed terms remove the strategic gaming that benefits the government of the day. Together, we can create a more predictable and fair democratic system for the next generation. Ultimately, our democratic priority should be greater capacity for voter representation and a contest of ideas, not a contest of timing. Thank you.

CHAIR: Thank you, Pamela, for your considered evidence today, and I appreciate you waiting till the end of the day. I saw you in the gallery there for a while. On expansion of parliament, this is sort of being done at a scale that's been proposed, by many witnesses and by many submissions, only twice before, and my understanding is that it didn't have bipartisan support—at the very least at the last time, in 1983. Do you feel, in 2025, something like this would need bipartisan support for it to go through, or do you feel like the reasons which you've given us there are strong enough for it to go without bipartisan support?

Mrs Rose: I think bipartisan support is incredibly important, and I hope that it would. Unfortunately, it's typically the LNP, or the 'no-alition', as they're often called, who will be against whatever the ALP is wanting to do. I think Australians deserve better. It shouldn't be about trying to show up the other party; it should be about what's best for the country. To your other point, as far as the timing goes, we have got a vastly different population to what we had then. I think we have to recognise just how large electorates are. I've been to see my local MP, and I know how long it takes to get to see her and the workload that they have. I would like to be able to feel confident that I can actually go to my local MP, raise an issue and have it addressed in a timely manner. As a private citizen, I want this so that I can be better represented and supported, especially as I have a son who uses the NDIS—so I've had to go to my MP in the past.

CHAIR: You mentioned capacity service. In your eyes, is that the biggest benefit for Australians? If there are more MPs, is access to their MPs what's most valuable to voters? Is that it?

Mrs Rose: I think it definitely is access for the individual voter, but it would also open up some more diversity in the representation by default.

CHAIR: Interestingly, the National Party supported the last expansion of parliament. It was Labor, the Nationals and others. Deputy Chair?

Senator COLBECK: In terms of your perspective on expansion, what do you see as the basis for where it might go to? Is there a preferred number of electors or best-in-class number of electors that might apply to where the parliament should land, in your view?

Mrs Rose: I do think that 100,000 should be the top limit for the number of constituents per MP. That seems to be, when I've had conversations with other people about that, what they feel is a reasonable number. I do know, in the past, it was 70,000—I think in the eighties. It would be good to have it a little bit under that 100,000. It might be with a redistribution that some electorates do fall into a range, but I think the upper limit should be 100,000.

Senator COLBECK: On fixed terms, what about other elements of the democratic process that a legislated fixed term would remove in terms of the supremacy of the parliament over the executive? How do you think those elements should be managed, if we were to, by legislating for fixed terms, remove the capacity of the parliament—I'm differentiating between that and the government as the executive, in respect of its decision-

making—and the very specific elements that are in the Constitution that are designed to manage the democratic process, which is what we're all about here, as part of our work?

Mrs Rose: I'm not sure I fully understand the question, sorry.

Senator COLBECK: There are some elements in respect of deadlocks between the House and the Senate, for example.

Mrs Rose: Are you talking about double dissolutions, or being able to call it early—

Senator COLBECK: Potentially, but also—and we're 50 years on from 1975—there are issues around supply. We can have an argument one way or the other about the rights or wrongs of that, and I'm trying to put that aside. There are mechanisms within the way our parliament and our democracy work that give primacy to the parliament. For me, that's the important part of the democratic process. Governments or parties may not like it, one way or the other, but that's the way the system works. How do we defend those important elements of our democratic process if we're moving to another system that removes the opportunity for those things—and the effects of those things—to work, in essence?

Mrs Rose: I think that, if an election were to be called early, it should only be for a very good reason. I don't think it should be used the way it's typically used now, as an advantage to the sitting government. If there is an issue where there's a deadlock or there are other issues where the government isn't able to properly represent then, of course, there needs to be some sort of—

Senator COLBECK: I'll go to my home state, where recently, 14 months after an election, there was a motion of no confidence in the government passed on the floor of the House—in the Premier but ergo the government, effectively. Tasmania has a fixed four-year term, no-one else was prepared to take up the treasury bench and they were given the opportunity. Where do you go from there if you're in the situation of a fixed term? How do you manage those sorts of elements, which, as we've just seen in Tasmania, are not completely outside the realm of things?

Mrs Rose: Obviously, you need to build exceptions into a fixed term, but I think the fixed term should be the goal and that there should be limited reason to call it early. I think that it's important to leave exactly how to design that to the political experts.

Senator COLBECK: We're undertaking a review of the electoral process and our electoral system. That's why we're asking these questions, because, at the end of the day, those that legislate it are sitting along this bench. We have colleagues and we'll recommend this evidence to our people.

Mrs Rose: On those finer details, I don't pretend to have the answers for those. I'm talking more broadly as far as the fact that—

Senator COLBECK: The view that you bring to this.

Mrs Rose: Yes. It's important to have a fixed term. Yes, it is important that there are exceptions but, at the moment, it's more strategic than it is about exceptions. It's more about when it is politically advantageous. That's what I have an issue with.

Senator COLBECK: Thank you.

CHAIR: Senator Mulholland, do you have any questions?

Senator MULHOLLAND: Hi, Mrs Rose. How are you? Thanks for joining us. You mentioned that you were involved in the campaign in the 2025 election. May I ask what campaign you were involved in?

Mrs Rose: Yes, it was the Ellie Smith campaign in Dickson.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Okay. We've heard from a couple of other volunteers involved in that campaign about what they witnessed at some of the prepolling booths. To call out a couple of things, there were significant volumes of campaign volunteers, some acting quite intensely, and a proliferation of signs. Then there were groups of cookie-cutter young men who all looked like they'd come off a factory conveyer belt or something. Do you have any of your own observations on those themes as well?

Mrs Rose: I did attend. I actually went to every single booth multiple times.

Senator MULHOLLAND: Lucky you!

Mrs Rose: I did see terrible behaviour, predominantly—actually, only—by the LNP. We'd have a volunteer that would be handing out and talking to a voter, and they would yell in front of them and say, 'No, don't listen to them,' and make claims that were not true. I think that that was incredibly disappointing. So I agree that there needs to be a limit to the number of candidate staff or volunteers that can be on the booths. The other thing that I

think could make a dramatic difference—I didn't mention it in my five-minute speech—is to only allow volunteers that live in the electorate. That would prevent the shipping in of people that are not—

Senator MULHOLLAND: Did you experience in Dickson that shipping in of people? Or you anticipated it?

Mrs Rose: I can only speculate that that may have happened. Actually, before the campaign, when there was some road signing, I do know that the Young LNP was brought in to do some work in Dickson. That's a completely different scenario, but I think that, if we were to have ID and if we were to register volunteers at the booths, then making that a requirement would even the playing field across all electorates and be representative of the community.

CHAIR: Dr Ryan.

Dr RYAN: It's an interesting idea—suggesting that you can only appear to support a candidate if you live in the electorate. Have you considered the fact that might actually be in contravention of the constitutional right of political expression? I suspect you might find that people would challenge that concept.

Mrs Rose: It's just a suggestion. The suggestion is made in good faith, trying to solve an issue of what we saw on election day. Merryl mentioned running the gauntlet. We look at elderly people and people with disabilities. We had some people who actually brought a caregiver with them. They were neurodivergent, and this was freaking them out. I think that it's important to protect people, and that is just one suggestion of how.

Dr RYAN: Sure. This is an observation, and I would want to ask what your thoughts are about it. In every city we have been to thus far, with maybe one exception, the majority of people, the citizens, who've come to give us feedback on community engagement and the experiences of the community have been from Independent candidates. Why do you think that might be?

Mrs Rose: I think that might be because we're politically engaged and we're motivated to see something different. It's more about participation and how we've been able to see, with campaigns like yours, that Independents can be successful.

Dr RYAN: Do you think that some of the experiences people have described at polling booths in Australia in 2025 would have dissuaded some people from coming back and volunteering again in future elections?

Mrs Rose: Absolutely. I'm positive that, just in our base of volunteers, many will not come back again. I counselled many volunteers that were quite distressed. That was part of my role of visiting all the different electorates—to check on the wellbeing of the volunteers and to try and pep them up, because it was very brutal. I did hear a quote that was used in the Groom campaign. Every time a volunteer was handing out for Suzie Holt, they would say, 'She's a teal; I'm the real deal,' to every single person. I don't think that's fair to the volunteers. I don't think that's fair to the general public. We need a better standard.

Dr RYAN: Thank you.

CHAIR: Mr Neumann.

Mr NEUMANN: You said you were across a number of different electorates. Were you the campaign manager in Dickson for the Independent?

Mrs Rose: I was for Dickson. Campaign managers on Independent campaigns, many of us spoke to each other, so I'm across what happened in Groom, for example.

Mr NEUMANN: I've been campaign manager, campaign director, for the Labor Party across the Ipswich region and around at local and state and federal levels before. In that role, you tend to engage a lot with the local returning officer and you'll speak to the person in charge of the booth and the AEC. I used to go in there and talk to them all the time. Did you do that? Did you engage with the local AEC people regularly?

Mrs Rose: I personally did not so much because I had quite a delegated team. I had a volunteer coordinator and another person that was working as a booth supervisor that helped to do that role.

Mr NEUMANN: So you didn't personally engage with the AEC?

Mrs Rose: I did not.

Mr NEUMANN: One of your responsibilities in a political party—and I know it is in the Labor Party—is that you look after the safety and security of your workers who work in the booths. We can take that back to higher up in the party, but ultimately on the ground you get a real sense of—I can't think of a better word than pastoral. You talked about counsel, and that's what your role is. How do you think we could improve safety and security in the polling booths? You said you went to all these different polling booths. How can we improve them?

Mrs Rose: I think it is about setting a standard across all of the candidates that are on the ballot, such as limiting the number of volunteers so that it's all the same across all of the candidates and not having that visual

clutter. I know that the Bunya site was actually just ridiculous. It was almost comical how much signage there was. I think setting standards would even the playing field.

Mr NEUMANN: We had evidence about at least one prepoll in Dickson. Were there issues in relation to toilet availability, ablutions availability, across Dickson?

Mrs Rose: I do know that it did happen at a couple, but the biggest issue was having to change shirts, to put a shirt over the top and that sort of thing.

Mr NEUMANN: When you say you know of issues, were they prevented?

Mrs Rose: As Carmel spoke earlier—

Mr NEUMANN: Were people prevented from using the toilets?

Mrs Rose: Yes, as Carmel mentioned earlier.

Mr NEUMANN: Was that at the request of the AEC?

Mrs Rose: As far as I'm aware.

Mr NEUMANN: It wasn't just at that one prepoll; it was at a number of prepolls.

Mrs Rose: I'm relying on memory, and I'm not a hundred per cent sure if—

Mr NEUMANN: That's fine.

CHAIR: Thank you very much for your time today. I appreciate it. That's it everyone.

Committee adjourned at 15:45